

MODERN HISTORY PRELIMS SMASHER

MODERN HISTORY PRELIMS SMASHER – Part 1

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MODERN HISTORY PRELIMS SMASHER – Part 2

1

The Advent of Europeans

in India

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following fruits: [2025]

I. Papaya

II. Pineapple

III. Guava

How many of the above were introduced in India by the Portuguese in the sixteenth and

seventeenth centuries?

(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All the three (d) None

2. Who among the following rulers of medieval Gujarat surrendered Diu to Portuguese? [2023]

(a) Ahmad Shah

(b) Mahmud Begarha

(c) Bahadur Shah

(d) Muhammad Shah

3. With reference to Indian history, Consider the following statements: [2022]

1. The Dutch established their factories/warehouses on the east coast on lands granted

to them by Gajapati rulers.

2. Alfonso de Albuquerque captured Goa from the Bijapur Sultanate.

3. The English East India Company established a factory at Madras on a plot of land

leased from a representative of the Vijayanagara empire.

Which of the statements given above are correct ?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only (c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

European entry into India began with Portuguese sea voyages for the spice trade, marked by Vasco da Gama's arrival in 1498. Naval

victories like Diu secured early Portuguese dominance, after which other

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2

European Powers in India – Comparative Analysis (1498–1954)

Aspect Portuguese

(1498–1961)

Dutch

(1602–1825)

British

(1600–1947)

Danes

(1616–1845)

French

(1664–1954)

Entry &

Background

y First Europeans to

arrive in India

after Vasco da

Gama (1498);

focused on

sea-borne trade +

religious

expansion

y Entered via

Dutch East

India Company

(VOC); purely

commercial

motives

y East India

Company (EIC)

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3

Major

Conflicts /

Turning

Points

y Naval dominance

in Indian Ocean;

Bahadur Shah

surrendered Diu

(1535)

y Defeated by

British at

Battle of

Chinsurah

(1759)

y Battles of

Plassey (1757),

Buxar (1764) â†’

Company rule

y Sold

settlements

to British

(1845)

y Lost Carnatic

Wars to British

Decline / Exit y Declined due to

weak economy &

British dominance;

retained Goa till

1961

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4

Battles of Plassey (1757) and Buxar (1764)

The Battles of Plassey (1757) and Buxar (1764) were decisive milestones in the rise of British power in India. While Plassey marked

the Company's political entry through intrigue, Buxar confirmed its military supremacy and secured territorial and revenue control,

laying the foundation of British rule.

Aspect Battle of Plassey (1757) Battle of Buxar (1764)

Place & Date y Plassey (Palashi), Bengal - 23 June 1757 y Buxar, Bihar - 22 October 1764

British Commander y Robert Clive y Hector Munro

Opponents y Siraj-ud-Daulah, Nawab of Bengal (with

nominal French support)

y Combined forces of Mir Qasim (Bengal),

Shuja-ud-Daulah (Awadh), Shah Alam II

(Mughal Emperor)

Nature of conflict y More a political conspiracy than a military contest

y A full-scale, open military battle

Key Causes y Misuse of dastaks (duty-free trade privileges)

y Illegal fortification of Fort William

y Shelter to Nawab's enemies (Krishna Das)

y Black Hole of Calcutta (1756) incident

y Continued misuse of dastaks

y British interference in Bengal administration

y Mir Qasim's abolition of transit duties to

ensure equal trade.

y British demand for preferential privileges

and political control

Course of battle y British success ensured by betrayal of Mir

Jafar, Jagat Seth, Rai Durlabh, Omichand

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5

Acts and Regulations in

British India (1773-1947)

British rule in India evolved from British East India Company control after the Battle of Plassey, gradually shifting from commercial

dominance to political authority. Following the Indian Rebellion of 1857, Company rule ended and governance passed directly to

the British Crown through the Government of India Act 1858.

Acts and Regulations under the East India Company

Company Rule in India refers to the period when the British East India Company exercised political power, beginning around 1757

(Plassey) or 1765 (Diwani grant). Regulated through successive Charter Acts, it ended in 1858 after the Indian Revolt of 1857.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. By which one of the following Acts was the Governor General of Bengal designated as the

Governor General of India? [2023]

(a) The Regulating Act

(b) The Pitt's India Act

(c) The Charter Act of 1793

(d) The Charter Act of 1833

2. Consider the following statements about the Charter Act of 1813: [2019]

1. It ended the trade monopoly of the East India Company in India except for trade in

tea and trade with China.

2. It asserted the sovereignty of the British Crown over the Indian territories held by the

Company.

3. The revenues of India were now controlled by the British Parliament.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only (c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Act and Leadership Key Provisions

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Charter Act, 1793 - To

renew Company rule for

20 years and strengthen

executive authority of the

Governor-General.

(Lord Cornwallis)

y The company had to pay 5 lakh pounds annually to the British government.

y “Country” (privilege) trade allowed: Company could license private traders and employees

to engage in country trade + facilitated opium shipments to China.

y Revenue administration was separated from judicial functions.

y Royal approval needed for appointment of GGoB, Governors and Commander-in-Chief.

y Salary of Company officials and Board of Control to be borne from Indian revenues.

y Senior officials cannot leave India without permission.

Charter Act, 1813

- Partial opening of trade;

tighter Parliamentary

control

(Lord Minto I)

y The company's trade monopoly ended except for tea and trade with China.

y Indian trade opened to British private merchants (under licence).

y Christian missionaries were permitted to enter India, educate and preach.

y Education grant of ₹1 lakh per year earmarked for literature, learning and science.

y Board of Control: Powers further enlarged over Company administration.

Charter Act, 1833

- Centralisation of

administration; end of

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Act (Year) and Viceroy Key Provisions

Government of India Act,

1858 - Transfer of power from

Company to Crown

(Lord Canning - 1st Viceroy of

India)

y Company rule abolished & Crown rule started

y Governor-General & Viceroy of India

y Office of Secretary of State for India created:

• He was a Member of the British Cabinet.

• Assisted by a 15-member Council of India.

y Dual control ended: Board of Control and Court of Directors abolished.

y Company's armed forces transferred to the Crown.

y Assurance of non-annexation of Princely States

Indian Councils Act, 1861

- Initiation of legislative

decentralisation after Crown

rule

(Lord Canning)

y Central Legislative Council expanded:

• 12 additional members; official majority retained.

y Provincial restoration: Legislative Councils revived in Bombay and Madras.

y Further provincial councils:

• Bengal (1862), North-Western Provinces (1886), Punjab (1897).

y First Indian representation at Centre; 3 Indians nominated:

• Raja of Benaras, Maharaja of Patiala, Sir Dinkar Rao.

y Portfolio system recognised (introduced earlier in 1859).

y Provincial law-making: Laws could be enacted for provinces.

y Ordinance power: Viceroy empowered to issue ordinances in emergencies

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8

Government of India Act,

1935 - Federal structure &

provincial autonomy

(Lord Willingdon)

y All-India Federation provided (never fully operational).

y Distribution of powers into three lists:

• Federal List: 59 (Defence, foreign affairs, currency, railways, communications,

banking, customs, inter-provincial trade).

• Provincial List: 54 (Law & order, education, agriculture, public health & sanitation).

• Concurrent List: 36.

• Residuary powers vested in the Viceroy.

y Provincial dyarchy abolished; provincial autonomy introduced (Ministers responsible to

legislatures).

• Implemented in 1937, suspended in 1939.

y Dyarchy at the Centre proposed (but never implemented).

y Council of India abolished (1858 Act body).

y Federal Court established (Privy Council to be final appellate authority).

y Reserve Bank of India provided for under the Act.

y The franchise expanded to around 10% of the population (still limited).

y Separate electorates extended to depressed classes, women, labour (communal

electorates retained; in place of reserved seats).

y Public Service Commissions: Provincial PSCs and Joint PSC provided.

y Bicameralism in provinces: Introduced in 6 of 11 - Bengal, Bombay, Madras, Bihar,

Assam, United Provinces.

Indian Independence Act,

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9

British Education System in India

The British introduced modern education in India to serve colonial needs and legitimise their rule. The Charter Act of 1813 formally

made education a state responsibility, placing it under the British East India Company.

British Policies in India

Person / Policy Core Focus

Warren Hastings y Established Calcutta Madrasa in 1781, to study Oriental learning (Arabic, Persian).

y Aimed at understanding the indigenous laws and elites.

William Jones y Asiatic Society of Bengal (1784) founded in Calcutta for Asiatic Researches and Sanskrit text

translations – institutionalised – Orientalism™.

Jonathan Duncan y In 1791, he established Sanskrit College in Benaras to study Hindu law and philosophy – Lord

Cornwallis (1786-93) sanctioned its establishment.

y Limited impact: As it had more teachers than students.

Lord Wellesley y Established Fort William College in Calcutta (1800) to train British administrators in Indian

languages and culture

Raja Ram Mohan

Roy, 1810s–20s

y Roy advocated English + Western sciences education.

y Opposed expansion of oriental colleges (famously protested the British government's proposal to

establish a new Sanskrit College in Calcutta in 1823).

y Notable contribution in establishment of Calcutta Hindu College in 1817.

General Committee

of Public

Instruction, 1823

y Established in 1823 to oversee and promote education in British India.

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10

William Bentinck,

(1828-1835)

- y Accepted Macaulay Committee report and prioritised English education

- y He replaced Persian with English as the official court language.

- y Backed the Downward Filtration Theory, relying on English-educated intermediaries.

- y Anglicists' victory in the Orientalist–Anglicist controversy:

- Anglicists: Western knowledge through English.

- Orientalists: Education in indigenous languages (Sanskrit/Persian).

Wood's Despatch,

1854

- y Issued by Sir Charles Wood (President of the BOC) to promote western education

- y Known as the 'Magna Carta of English Education in India.'

- y The Department of Public Instruction (DPI) was set up in each province (1855), replacing earlier

bodies.

- y Calcutta, Bombay, Madras Universities established in 1857 (University of London model).

- y Graded system: Elementary → Middle → High Schools → Colleges.

- y Training institutions established on English lines.

- y Language policy:

- Vernacular at primary level.

- Anglo-vernacular at secondary level.

- English at higher education level.

- y Financial support to private institutions, conditional on qualified teachers and prescribed standards.

- y Emphasis on women's education and encouragement to vocational education.

Hunter

Commission,

1882-83

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11

British Policies on Princely States

During the intense rivalry with France, the British in India, especially Lord Wellesley, initiated a major expansion of British rule,

which was continued by later Governors-General to bring most princely states under British control.

Policy Core Features

Wars with

regional powers

(1767-1849)

y Failed diplomacy to subdue → direct military conquest → Annexation & Control through treaties or

absorption → Rapid territorial expansion.

y Anglo-Mysore Wars: 1767-1799; Anglo-Maratha Wars: 1775-1818; Anglo-Sikh Wars: 1845-1849

Policy of Ring

Fence

(1765-1813)

(Warren

Hastings)

y Defensive strategy to secure territories by containing Mysore, Marathas, and guarding against

Afghan threats (North-west).

y British territories surrounded by friendly buffer states to prevent direct confrontation.

y British troops stationed in allied states, cost borne by princely states.

y Non-interference in internal administration of allied states.

Subsidiary

Alliance

(1798-1805)

(Lord Wellesley)

y States had to station and fund British troops + A mandatory British

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12

Carnatic Wars (1746-1763)

The Carnatic Wars were 18th-century conflicts in South India between the British and French East India Companies, driven by rivalry

for trade and territory. They ended French ambitions and established British supremacy in India.

Background & Overview of Carnatic Wars

Series of three wars (1746–1763) between the British East India Company and the French East India Company

Fought mainly in the Carnatic (present-day Tamil Nadu and adjoining areas).

Indian theatre of Anglo-French rivalry linked to European wars:

• War of Austrian Succession • First Carnatic War.

• Seven Years' War • Third Carnatic War

First Carnatic War (1746-1748)

Causes • British naval action under Commodore Barnett seized French ships.

• Neutrality talks between Dupleix (Pondicherry) and Governor Morse (Madras) collapsed.

Course of the

War

• Capture of Madras (1746) • French forces under La Bourdonnais captured Madras • Dupleix

falsely promised Nawab Anwar-ud-din to hand Madras to him, later reneged.

• Battle of Adyar / San Thome (1746) • Nawab's army led by Mahfuz Khan defeated by French forces,

proving European military superiority • Dupleix targeted Fort St. David (under British) • British

attempts to capture Pondicherry failed.

Outcome • Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle (1748): It ended the war and Madras returned to the British in exchange for

Louisbourg (North America) • Beginning of decisive Anglo-French rivalry in Indian politics.

Second Carnatic War (1749-1754)

Causes • Despite peace in Europe, British and French rivalry continued in

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13

Anglo-Mysore Wars (1767-1799)

The Anglo-Mysore Wars were a series of four major 18th-century conflicts between the British East India Company and the Kingdom

of Mysore, led by rulers like Hyder Ali and Tipu Sultan, for supremacy in South India. These wars reshaped regional power dynamics

and ultimately facilitated British consolidation of control in southern India.

Background

Overview y Late 18th century – Series of four conflicts between Mysore and British East India Company – British

backed by Marathas, Hyderabad & Travancore – Prolonged Anglo-Mysore Wars – Struggle for

political and military supremacy in South India.

Wodeyar

Dynasty and

Rise of Mysore

y Battle of Talikota (1565) – Collapse of Vijayanagara Empire – successor states rise – Wodeyar

kingdom founded in Mysore (1612) – Reign of Chikka Krishnaraja Wodeyar II (1734–1766); nominal

king, ministers wield real power – Mysore emerged strong regional power under Haidar Ali and Tipu

Sultan (18th century) – British threat perception heightens (French alliance + Malabar coast trade

control + pressure on Madras Presidency)

Rise of Haidar

Ali

y Maratha & Nizam invasions weaken Mysore – leadership vacuum created – Haidar Ali emerged de

facto ruler, sidelining Wodeyar king (1761) – He modernised military with French help (1761–1763)

(arms factory at Dindigul) – Territorial expansion through war + diplomacy (1761–1763) – Dod

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14

Third Anglo-Mysore War (1789-1792)

Background y Tipu (Mysore) – Travancore dispute – Travancore buys Jalkottal & Cannanore from Dutch (Cochin

region) – Tipu asserts sovereignty (As Cochin being Mysore vassal) – British back Travancore –

hostilities begin – Tipu declares war on Travancore (April 1790) – Outbreak

Course of the

War

y Tipu Sultan defeats British forces (1790) – Lord Cornwallis assumes command (1791) – British

capture Ambur, Vellore & Bangalore (1791) – British advance with Maratha & Nizam support (1791 –

1792) – Tipu retreats towards Seringapatam (1791 – 1792) – Stiff resistance – Fall of Seringapatam

(1792)

Outcome y End of war with Treaty of Seringapatam (1792) – half of Mysore's territory was ceded – British:

Baramahal, Dindigul, Malabar; Marathas: Tungabhadra basin; Nizam: Krishna – Pennar doab – Tipu

Sultan pays war indemnity (1792) – Two sons of Tipu taken as hostages (1792)

Fourth Anglo-Mysore War (1798-1799)

Background y Tipu's sons released amid Tipu's compliance with Treaty of Seringapatam – Wodeyar ruler death

(1796) – Tipu proclaims himself Sultan (instead of minor son of Wodeyar ruler)

y Lord Wellesley appointed (1798) – Policy of expansion – Alarm over Tipu's French links (France /

Isle of France) – Subsidiary Alliance pushed + Tipu accused of foreign outreach (Nizam, Marathas,

Zaman Shah, France) – Explanations rejected – Outbreak

Course of the

War

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15

Maratha

Confederacy

Confederate state = Peshwa + powerful chiefs.

y Peshwa (Poona): Nominal head

y Scindia (Gwalior): North India

y Holkar (Indore): Malwa

y Bhonsle (Nagpur): Central India

y Gaekwad (Baroda): Gujarat

British Entry

into Maratha

Politics

y The British exploited Maratha fragmentation to replicate Clive's Bengal model of control.

y Succession disputes provided the pretext for intervention, leading to the Anglo-Maratha Wars.

First Anglo-Maratha War (1775-1782)

Background y Death of Peshwa Madhav Rao I (1772) → weak successor Narayan Rao → assassination (1773)

allegedly by Raghunath Rao → succession dispute → Barbhai Council installs infant Madhav Rao II

under Nana Phadnavis → Raghunath Rao seeks British support - Treaty of Surat (1775) → British

intervention

Course of the

War

y 1775: British support Raghunath Rao → advance towards Poona → Maratha resistance hardens

y 1779: Battle of Wadgaon → British force surrounded and defeated by Marathas

y 1779: Treaty of Wadgaon → British agree to relinquish gains since 1775

y 1781: British reject Wadgaon terms → renewed fighting under Warren

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16

Anglo-Sikh Wars (1845-49)

The Anglo-Sikh Wars (1845–1849) were fought between the Sikh Empire and the British East India Company, resulting in the fall

of Sikh power and British annexation of Punjab. Their outcome ended one of the last major independent Indian states before the

Revolt of 1857.

Background Triggers

y Death of Ranjit Singh (1839) → Led to succession disputes, factionalism, weak rulers → Army leadership undermined

by treachery (Lal Singh, Teja Singh) → British expansion reaches Sutlej frontier → tensions escalate → British

strategy shifts to exploiting internal instability over direct aggression

First Anglo-Sikh War (1845-1846)

Background y Under political chaos after Ranjit Singh's death Sikh Army crossed Sutlej → British perceiving threat,

used internal divisions by their side triggering war

Course of War y Battle of Mudki (1845): British victory.

y Battle of Ferozeshah (1845): Heavy losses of British who barely managed to secure the victory.

y Battle of Aliwal (1846): Sikh defeat by the British led by Sir Harry Smith.

y Battle of Sobraon (1846): Sikh resistance broken leading to the occupation of Lahore by the British.

Outcome y Treaty of Lahore (March 1846) ended the first Anglo-Sikh War → Sikh army reduced; Maharaja

Duleep Singh recognised as ruler; Rani Jindan as regent; Kashmir transferred to Gulab Singh for ₹175

lakh.

y Treaty of Amritsar (1846): A follow-up treaty recognised Gulab Singh as ruler of Jammu & Kashmir.

y Treaty of Bhairawal (1846): Rani Jindan deposed and placed a British Resident in charge of Lahore..

Second Anglo-Sikh War (1848-49)

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17

Supreme Court at

Calcutta, 1774

- Under Regulating

Act, 1773

y The supreme court applied English law and had jurisdiction over British subjects.

y SC had jurisdiction in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa – later Madras and Bombay Supreme Courts

were established in 1801 and 1823, respectively.

y In cases exceeding Rs 4000 appeal lie to the London Privy Council.

y Conflict with Company courts (Adalats) and the Governor-General-in-Council.

y Created dual judiciary (Supreme Courts and Sadar Adalats).

Cornwallis Judicial

Reforms, 1780s –

1790s (Foundation of

independent

judiciary

y The reforms separated revenue from the judiciary (Cornwallis Code).

y Civil courts reorganised – Europeans were not subject to Indian courts; jurisdictional

complexities existed. – Abolished District Faujdari Courts.

y Established European-judged circuit courts at Calcutta, Dacca, Murshidabad, and Patna for civil

and criminal appeals.

Law Commission

(1833)

- Under T B

Macaulay

y Established to codify Indian laws.

y It eventually resulted in the Indian Penal Code (the Western-derived Codes

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18

Charter Act (1833) y Proposed open competition for civil services (in principle).

y Ended Company's commercial functions â†' Company became administrative body.

y Provided legal basis for merit-based recruitment, though implementation delayed.

Committee on the

Indian Civil Service

(Macaulay Committee)

(1854)

- Chaired by: T B

Macaulay

y Recommended open competitive examinations.

y Recommended abolition of Company's patronage-based system for recruitment.

y Set a certain age limit (minimum of 18 to 25 years) for admission in Haileybury college.

y The first competitive examination was held in London in 1855.

y Laid blueprint of modern civil service.

Government of India

Act, 1858

y Civil services transferred from Company to British Crown.

y The Secretary of State for India assumed ultimate control over civil services.

The Indian Civil

Service Act, 1861

y Reserved key posts for the Covenanted Service.

y Opened certain posts to Indians under specified qualifications.

y Required a vernacular language test for district service.

y Failed to satisfy demands for Indianisation of services.

y It remained a dead letter (due to reluctance of authorities, recruitment and procedural difficulties).

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19

Press in India during British Rule

The press in India developed during British rule as a medium for communication and public awareness. Despite official restrictions, it gradually became a powerful instrument of political expression and nationalism.

Policy / Measure Core Provisions

Early Company

Phase (pre-1799)

- y No formal censorship law enacted by the Company.
- y Press functioned under informal tolerance, not statutory freedom.
- y Freedom by neglect, not by any recognised legal right.

Censorship of the

Press Act, 1799

(Lord Wellesley)

- y Pre-censorship introduced for the first time.
- y Prior approval mandatory before publication of newspapers/material.
- y Editors required to submit content to government scrutiny.
- y Aimed at preventing anti-British and pro-French propaganda.
- y First direct state control over the press in India.
- y Marked shift from informal tolerance to active regulation.

Press Ordinance or

Licensing Regulation

(1823)

John Adam

(Adam's Regulation)

- y Licensing of presses made compulsory.
- y Government empowered to cancel licences arbitrarily
- y Applied stringent controls + short but severe repression of the press.
- y Continued under Lord William Bentinck.
- y Opposition:

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Defence of India Act

1915

- y To curtail press freedom and political dissent during WWI.

- y Government empowered to restrict publications, censor news, and suppress political

agitation.

- y Allowed preventive detention, bans on meetings, and controls on communication.

- y Operated through executive orders, not regular judicial processes.

- y Set the template for extraordinary powers later continued under the Rowlatt Act (1919)

(peace-time extension).

Press Emergency

Powers Act (1931)

(Lord Willingdon)

- y Granted summary powers to the executive to suppress nationalist newspapers.

- y Operated without prolonged judicial process (administrative discretion).

- y Targeted Congress and nationalist propaganda during the Civil Disobedience phase.

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21

British Land Revenue Policies

The land revenue system in British India was a core component of colonial administration designed to maximise revenue through systems like Permanent Settlement, Ryotwari, and Mahalwari. These policies fundamentally reshaped agrarian relations and became the main source of income for the colonial state.

British Economic Policies

Revenue System Core Features

Revenue Farming

(Ijardari System)

(1765–1772)

- y Under early East India Company in Bengal – Revenue collection auctioned to contractors

- (Ijardars) who were free to extract revenue.

- y No fixed assessment and extreme peasant exploitation.

- y It was abolished after 1772 due to chaos and famine.

Permanent

Settlement (1793)

- y Introduced by Cornwallis in Bengal, Bihar, Orissa and parts of Banaras

- y Zamindars were made hereditary landowners (earlier only tax collectors).

- y State fixed permanent revenue demand ($\frac{10}{11}$ th of rent); zamindars kept $\frac{1}{11}$ th.

- y Zamindars retained all future rent increases.

- y Sunset Clause: Payment by sunset of due date mandatory; default meant confiscation and

- auction.

- y State lost share in rising agricultural surplus

- y It favoured landlords and hurt peasants. Also there was no incentive for state investment.

- y It created a large number of absentee landlords.

- y Nearly half the land was sold (1794-1807) due to high revenue demands.

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22

Trade and Agriculture in British India

Trade and agriculture in British India were reshaped to meet colonial needs, driven by railways, ports, and communication networks.

This led to commercialisation of agriculture, export of raw materials, and import of British manufactures, transforming India's

economy.

Transport and Communication

River

Transport

- On major rivers (Ganga, Indus, Brahmaputra) to move troops and bulk goods efficiently.

- Supplementing canals (like the Ganga Canal) for irrigation, transport.

- Integrated with ports (Calcutta, Bombay, Madras) to export raw material, import finished goods.

Railways • Railway idea backed by Lord Hardinge (1844) – private companies permitted (for imperial & military

security)

- Railway Minute by Lord Dalhousie (1853) – policy framework for expansion – Core motives –

economic exploitation + administrative integration + military mobility

- Construction model – British capital + guaranteed 5% return – losses borne by Indian revenues

- First passenger train: Bombay (Bori Bandar) – Thane, 34 km (16 April 1853)

- Raw-material corridors – cotton (Deccan), jute (Bengal), coal (Raniganj) linked to ports

- Acworth Committee (1920–21) recommends state control – Separate Railway Budget introduced

(1924)

Postal Services • Posts opened to public by Warren Hastings (March 1774) – Shift from Company correspondence

to state-regulated postal service.

- Lord Dalhousie (Father of the modern Postal system) introduces Post Office

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Commercialisation Of Agriculture

y Subsistence farming → market-oriented production (cash crops) → Cotton, Jute, Indigo, Rubber, Sugarcane, Tea, Coffee.

→ 19th-century acceleration driven by railways, ports, telegraph, and imperial integration.

Indigo Cultivation

Forms y Nij cultivation, where planters controlled land and hired laborers → Planters coerced peasants into contracts to

supply indigo through village headmen and cash advances.

Policies y Planters used threats, violence, and legal pressure to enforce indigo cultivation + Dadan advances at high

interest caused perpetual indebtedness + Indigo grown on fertile land and soil exhaustion led to food scarcity +

Colonial courts and administration favoured European planters → Led to the Indigo Revolt (1859-60) →

Indigo Act, 1862 (ended compulsory indigo cultivation; ryots could refuse contracts) → Planters moved to

Champaran (Bihar) to continue indigo under new arrangements → Champaran Satyagraha (April 1917) →

Edward Gait Committee (June 1917) examined Champaran grievances, exposing planter exploitation →

Ended by the early 20th century due to cheaper synthetic dyes.

Trade Pattern during British India

India was reduced to a raw-material supplier and market for British manufactures.

y Exports: Raw cotton, jute, indigo, tea and coffee (export oriented + European controlled), silk, spices, oilseeds, saltpetre,

opium (Bengal → China; major revenue, linked to Opium Wars).

y Imports: Cotton textiles (Lancashire), woollens, machinery (served colonial interests) and railway equipment.

y Cotton: Civil War (1861–65) boom accelerated agricultural commercialisation in Deccan & Central India.

y Textiles: British imports destroyed Indian handlooms →

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24

Factories Act, 1891 y Child labour regulation:

- Minimum age raised from 7 to 9 years.

- Upper age bracket extended from 12 to 14 years.

- Children's working hours reduced to 7 hours/day.

- y Women working hours fixed at 11 hours/day.

- y Weekly holiday introduced for the first time.

- y Men's working hours remained unregulated.

- y Applied to factories using power.

- y Excluded British-owned tea and coffee plantations.

Factories Act, 1911 y Adult male working hours regulated for the first time:

- Maximum 12 hours/day (1911 Act).

- Reduced to 11 hours/day by the 1922 amendment.

- y Child labour safeguards strengthened (better regulation than 1891 Act).

- y Extended coverage to seasonal factories.

- y Broader scope compared to 1881 and 1891 Acts.

Workmen's

Compensation Act, 1923

- y Built upon earlier laws: Compensation Act, 1884, Fatal Accidents Act, 1885

- y Compensation payable to workers for injury/death arising out of and in the course of

employment.

- y Established strict / no-fault liability • employer liable without proving negligence.

- y Covered specified employments; cash compensation standardized by schedules.

- y Agricultural labour excluded from the Act's coverage.

Trade Unions Act, 1926 y Trade Unions (TUs) legalised and registration framework established.

- y Registered TUs granted limited immunity:

- From civil liability in trade disputes.

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25

Defence of India Rules

(1939-1945)

y Enforced during Second World War to ensure uninterrupted industrial and wartime

production.

y Made strikes and lockouts illegal without a specified notice period.

y Government empowered to refer industrial disputes to compulsory conciliation and

adjudication.

Economic Critique of British Imperialism

Economic nationalism became a core strand of the Indian national movement in the late 19th and early 20th centuries,

emerging from a sustained critique of colonial economic policies by early nationalist leaders through writings, speeches,

and public advocacy.

Thinker Core Contributions / Arguments

Dadabhai

Naoroji

y Propounded Drain Theory in his famous book “Poverty and the Un-British Rule in India”.

y Wealth drained via “Home Charges” (trade surplus, salaries, pensions, remittances).

y Drain of 1/2 of govt revenue and “ of national savings.

y Result: Britain’s enrichment + India’s impoverishment.

Romesh

Chunder Dutt

y Author of Economic History of India (based on official records).

y Criticised exploitative land revenue and taxation policies.

y Highlighted decline of Indian textiles and handloom industry.

y According to him, railways aided import penetration, not Indian industrialisation.

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The Revolt of 1857 was a widespread uprising against British rule, involving sepoys, princes, and civilian populations across

northern and central India. It marked the first major challenge to colonial authority and became a turning point in the history

of British rule in India.

Causes

Political y Annexation of states like Satara, Jhansi, Nagpur (Doctrine of Lapse) + Annexation of Awadh

fuelled resentment.

y Loss of authority and privileges of Landlords, Zamindars and Princes.

â™‚ Bahadur Shah II felt humiliated as his successors were barred from the Red Fort

Military y Sepoys faced racial discrimination, low pay, inferior conditions, exclusion from higher ranks â†’

General Service Enlistment Act 1856 required service overseas, violating religious customs

Economic y Heavy taxationâ†’ land alienation + peasant misery.

y Forced cultivation of indigo and opium â†’ famines and food shortages.

y Drain of Indiaâ€™s wealth to Britain without adequate returns, impoverishing the country.

y Deindustrialisation â†’ Destruction of indigenous handicrafts, leaving artisans jobless and India

dependent on British imports.

Socio - religious y Religious interferenceâ†’ Abolition of sati and legalization of widow remarriage by British â†’

alienated conservative sections.

y Racial discrimination like segregation in public places, discriminatory justice system

y Pandits, Maulvis, and other religious leaders lost their traditional influence under British rule.

Immediate Cause y Introduction of the Enfield Rifle and the greased cartridges, rumored to be coated with animal fat,

specifically from cows and pigs â†’ Triggered revolt

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27

Causes of the failure of the Revolt

Weak leadership y The revolt lacked a clear political vision or coordination and had no central command; leaders acted independently.

Limited unity y Confined regionally; Punjab and South stayed loyal; internal divisions persisted.

Elite non-support y Educated Indians viewed the revolt as regressive.

British military

superiority

y Britishers had superior arms, organisation structure and efficient leaderships.

Harsh repression y Brutal retaliations by British forces crushed the revolt.

Centres of Revolt Leaders British Resistance

Delhi General Bakht Khan Lieutenant Willoughby, John Nicholson, Lieutenant Hudson

Kanpur Nana Saheb Sir Hugh Wheeler, Sir Colin Campbell

Lucknow Begum Hazrat Mahal Henry Lawrence, Brigadier Inglis, Henry Havelock, James

Outram, Sir Colin Campbell

Bareilly Khan Bahadur Khan Sir Colin Campbell

Arrah (Bihar) Kunwar Singh William Taylor

Faizabad Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah James Outram

Jhansi Rani Laxmibai Sir Hugh Rose

Allahabad and Benaras Maulvi Liaqat Ali Colonel James Neill

Description of the Revolt of 1857

V.D. Savarkar War of Independence

R.C. Majumdar Neither the First nor the National War of Independence

T. R. Holmes A significant conflict between civilisation and barbarism

Lawrence and Seeley Mere sepoy mutiny

James Outram A coordinated effort by both Hindus and Muslims against British rule

MODERN HISTORY PRELIMS SMASHER

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28

Tribal Revolts in British India

Tribal revolts in British India were localised uprisings by indigenous communities against colonial policies and external exploitation.

They arose from disruptions to traditional livelihoods, land systems, and forest rights. These revolts represent an important strand

of early resistance to British rule.

Tribal and Peasant Movements

Revolt Tribe/Leader/Region Core Causes / Features

Pahariya Rebellion

(late 18th Cen.)

y Leader: Raja Jagganath

y Pahariya tribes of Rajmahal Hills

y Against the British extension of settled agriculture into the

Pahariya territories.

y Encroachment by zamindars; revenue demands

Chuar Rebellion

(1766-1799)

y Chuar tribals of Jungle Mahals in

Bengal

y Leader: Durjan Singh

y Series of uprisings between 1766 and 1799.

y Land revenue oppression – It led to the execution and displacement of hundreds of rebels

Tamar Revolts

(1789-1832)

y Tamar tribes (Oraon, Munda) in

the Chotanagpur region.

y Leader: Bhola Nath Sahay

y British decision to impose tax on tribal groups.

y Other tribals from adjoining regions also joined

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Koya Rebellion

(1879-80)

y Koya tribals of Godavari

Agency (AP)

y Tomma Dora

y Erosion of customary rights, Forest laws; moneylender
exploitation

y Influenced Rampa Rebellion of 1922-1924

Munda Rebellion

or Ulgulan or the

Great Tumult

(1899-1900)

y Leader: Birsa Munda

(Dharti Aba)

y Chotanagpur region

y Forest laws; forced labour (beth begari); zamindari
oppression

y Destruction of traditional land system (Khuntkatti system).

y Messianic leadership

y Led to Chotanagpur Tenancy Act 1908.

Bastar Rebellion

(1910)

y Bastar tribals y Forest reservation; forced labour; admin control

y It resulted in the temporary suspension of forest
reservation and a reduction of the reserved area by about
half

Tana Bhagat

Movement

(1914-21)

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Peasant Revolts in British India

Peasant revolts in British India were organised protests by cultivators against oppressive agrarian policies and exploitative revenue

arrangements. They emerged from economic distress and changing rural power structures under colonial rule. These movements

highlight the agrarian roots of resistance in colonial India.

Revolt (Year) Leader / Region Core Causes / Key Takeaways

Sanyasi -Fakir

Rebellion

(1763-1800)

y Sanyasis and Fakirs in Bengal

and Bihar

y Leaders: Pandit Bhabani

Charan Pathak, Debi

Chaudhurani, Majnu Shah

Fakir, Musa Shah, Chirag Ali

y Reasons: Revenue pressure after Diwani (1765)

y Causes: British restrictions on pilgrims visiting Hindu and

Muslim holy places, distress due to the Bengal famine of 1770.

y It was an early religious anti-Company resistance – Sanyasi

Attacks in Rangpur and Dinajpur (1770s) and 1771 Battle

y Anandamath (by B C Chattopadhyay) based on Sanyasi revolts.

Narkelberia

Uprising (1782-

1831)

y West Bengal region

y Leader: Mir Nithar Ali (Titu

Mir)

y Reason: Muslim tenants – fight against beard tax by landlords on

Faraizis.

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Pabna Agrarian

Unrest (1873-76)

y Bengal Peasants

y Leaders: Ishan Chandra

Roy, Shambhu Nath Pal,

Khodi Mulla

y Reasons: Zamindari oppression aimed at nullifying ryots'™

occupancy rights recognised under the Act of 1859 through illegal seizures, rent hikes, forced agreements, evictions etc.

y Movement suppressed by armed intervention; later an enquiry committee led to the enactment of the Bengal Tenancy Act of 1885.

Deccan Riots

(1875)

y Maharashtra

y Decentralised leadership

from local village headmen,

and the general cultivator

class.

y Reasons: Uprising against exploitative moneylenders (Sahukars)

â†' favoured by Ryotwari system over cultivators, intensifying caste divisions.

â™| Cotton price collapse post-American civil war expanding satta (loan) â†' peasant distress deepened.

â™| Commercial farming, cotton crop failures, and usurious interest rates pushed peasants into perpetual indebtedness.

y Outcome: It led to Deccan Agriculturists Relief Act 1879.

Kisan Sabha

Movement

(1918-22)

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32

Sepoy Mutinies in British India

Sepoy mutinies were early military uprisings by Indian soldiers employed in the British colonial army during the late 18th and early

19th centuries. They reflected growing discontent over service conditions, religious sensitivities, and colonial policies. These mutinies

are seen as precursors to organised resistance against British rule.

Revolt (Year) Core Features

Sepoy Mutiny in

Bengal, 1766

(Monghyr Mutiny)

y By the Bengal native infantry sepoys of the East India Company.

y Occurred shortly after the pivotal Battle of Buxar (1764).

y Reason: Discontent over low pay, poor service conditions, and discrimination against Indian

sepoys.

y Limited in spread and organisation; exposed early fissures in Company's "sepoy relations."

y Quickly suppressed by the Company

Vellore Mutiny

(1806)

y Vellore Fort (Tamil Nadu) served as the centre of the 1806 mutiny of the Madras Army sepoys.

y Reason: Sepoys revolted over dress code changes at Vellore Fort.

â™¦ Andrew's Hut regulations (to secularise and homogenise the army)

â†' fear of forced cultural transformation among sepoys.

â™¦ Caste mark removal and new hat from cow and pig hides hurt religious sentiments.

y The British suppressed the mutiny, executing 100 sepoys and disbanding regiments.

Barrackpore

Mutiny or Mutiny

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33

The socio-religious reform movements emerged in India during the 19th century as responses to social evils and the impact of Western ideas. Led by Indian reformers, they sought to reinterpret tradition while promoting social rationality and moral reform. These movements contributed significantly to social transformation and the growth of modern Indian consciousness.

Socio-Religious Reform

Movements

Factors leading to Socio-Religious Reform Movements

- y Western conquest exposed social evils like sati, infanticide, and child marriage.
- y British rule enabled intellectual awakening, aided by press freedom.
- y Reformers sought social change through legislation and social work.
- y Society split between traditionalists and Western-influenced reformers.
- y Modern ideas of science, reason, and humanism gained appeal.
- y New social classes pushed for modernisation.

Reform Movements Among Hindus

Reformer /

Movement (Year)

Key Leader(s)

/ Region / Core Ideas and Reforms

Atmiya Sabha (1815) y Founded by Raja Ram Mohan Roy in Kolkata (1815) â†’ Functioned as philosophical

discussion circle â†’ Opposed idolatry, rigid caste system & meaningless rituals â†’ Promoted

socialâ€“religious reform through rational debate â†’ Precursor to the Brahmo Samaj

Brahmo Samaj (1828) y Founded by Raja Ram Mohan Roy (earliest propagator of modern education) in Bengal and

continued by Devendranath Tagore (post 1843) and K C Sen (post 1866).

y Twin pillars: 1) Reason and 2) Vedas and Upanishads

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Raja Ram Mohan Roy

y Roy upholds monotheism & rationalism â†' Critiques idolatry, caste rigidity & ritualism â†'

Attacks priestly class for sustaining superstition â†' Translates Vedas & five major Upanishads

into Bengali â†' Condemns social evils (Sati) â†' Synthesises Eastern philosophy with rational,

scientific thought â†' Advocates social equality grounded in human dignity

y Founded Vedanta College (1825) with the help of David Hare â†' Western social and physical

sciences courses â†' Maintained English School in Calcutta (1817) at his own cost.

y Major Works (with years): Vedanta (1815), Ishopanishad (1816), Kathopanishad (1817),

Manduk Upanishad (1819), The Precepts of Jesus (1820), Sambad Kaumudi (1821), Mirat-ul-

Akbar (1822), Bengali Grammar (1826), Brahmapasona (1828), Brahmasangeet (1829), The

Universal Religion (1829), etc.

Young Bengal

Movement (1820s-30s)

y Henry Vivian Derozio Founder, part of a radical trend in Bengal (1820s-30s) but was short-lived

y Teaches at Hindu College (1826â€“1831) â†' promotes free, critical thinking â†' Attacks orthodox

customs, rites & traditions â†' challenges social and religious conservatism â†' Advocates social

reform & womenâ€™s rights â†' Limitation â†' did not take up peasant issues

y The â€˜Society for the Acquisition of General Knowledgeâ€™ founded in 1838.

y Key publications: Parthenon, Hesperus, Jnanannesan, Enquirer, Hindu Pioneer, Quill, Bengal

Spectator, and The East Indian (Derozioâ€™s own daily).

Debendranath Tagore y Debendranath Tagore blends Indian tradition with

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Bal Shastri

Jambhekar

y Earliest social reformer of Bombay Presidency + Critiques Brahmanical orthodoxy + seeks

reform of popular Hindu practices.

y Starts Darpan weekly journal (1832) + to dispel ignorance & superstition + spread modern

knowledge + Inspired by contemporary European intellectual progress.

Paramahansa

Mandali (1849)

y Founded in Maharashtra by Durgaram Mehtaji and Dadoba Pandurang.

y Functioned secretly due to strong social opposition.

y It believed in one God, aimed to break rigid caste rules, opposed idolatry, practised inter caste

dining, supported women's education and widow remarriage.

y Established branches in Poona, Satara, and other towns of Maharashtra.

Gopal Hari Deshmukh y A leading social reformer and advocate of modern learning in Maharashtra who Wrote under the

pen name ~Lokahitawadi~.

y Authored the famous ~Shatpatre~ (100 letters) in the Marathi weekly Prabhakar (1848~1850)

which critically examined almost all aspects of society.

Veda Samaj (1864) y Veda Samaj founded in Madras by Sridharalu Naidu & Keshab Chandra Sen + Strong

influence of Brahmo Samaj + Marriage & funeral rites treated as social practices (not rigid

rituals)

y Reform agenda + removal of sectarianism + gradual dilution of caste distinctions + tolerance of

diverse views + opposition to polygamy & child marriage + Support for widow remarriage

Prarthana Samaj

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Deccan Education

Society (1884)

• Emerged as influential social & political organisation in Maharashtra
• Founded after New

English School, Pune • Founders: Gopal Ganesh Agarkar & Bal Gangadhar Tilak
• Pioneers

indigenous mass education • breaks state & missionary monopoly • Key contributors

Vishnushastri Chiplunkar, M. G. Ranade, Mahadev Ballal, Namjoshi, V. S. Apte, V. B. Kelkar,

M. S. Gole, N. K. Dharwadkar • Establishes Fergusson College • Pune's first institution of higher education

Dev Samaj (1887) • Founded in Lahore by Pandit Shiv Narayan Agnihotri • Rejects contemporary Hindu

rituals & deity worship • Worship of true Guru (Dev Bhagvan Atma) • Promotes inter-

dining & inter caste marriage • Advocates education for men & women • Opens

co-educational school at Moga • later Dev Samaj High School • Dev Samaj Balika

Vidyalaya established for girls (1901).

Self-Respect

Movement or Suya

Mariyadhai Iyakkam

(1925)

• Self-Respect Movement founded by E V Ramaswamy Naicker with S. Ramanathan •

Challenges Brahminical dominance • opposes caste discrimination • Promotes self-respect

among lower castes • Emphasises dignity, equality, social justice & rationalism • Kudi Arasu

weekly launched as movement's organ (1924) • Later publications by Naicker - Viduthalai

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37

Movement (Year) Key Leader(s) / Region / Core Ideas and Reforms

Kuka Movement

(Namdhari

Movement) (1872)

y Initiated by Bhagat Jawaharmal & Baba Balak Singh â†' Transforms into religio-political

revival under Baba Ram Singh (disciple of Baba Balak Singh)

y Core teachings of Baba Ram Singh â†' Worship of one God through prayer and meditation +

Strict moral discipline through Rehatnamas (codes of conduct) + Opposition to caste system,

infanticide, early marriage, and barter of daughters + Promotion of simple Anand Marriage.

Singh Sabha

Movement (1873)

y Arises after suppression of Kuka (Namdhari) Movement â†' Wider mass base among Sikhs â†'

Leadership drawn mainly from educated Sikh middle class â†' Linked with broader Punjab

reform movements â†' Focus â†' socio-religious reform through education (not politics) â†'

Strategy â†' avoided confrontation with British (landed & community interests)

y Khalsa College founded at Amritsar (1892) with British support â†' Promoted Punjabi language,

Gurmukhi script & Sikh religious education

Akali Movement in

Punjab (1920-25)

y Emerged from Singh Sabha â†' mass movement â†' Reform of Gurudwara administration â†'

Targets corrupt mahants controlling endowed shrines â†' Launches Satyagraha against mahants

& British-backed authorities (1921) â†' Sikh Gurudwaras Act secured (1922;

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38

Reform /

Development (Year)

Key Leader(s)

/ Region / Core Ideas and Reforms

Bengal Sati Regulation,

1829

y Personalities – Raja Ram Mohan Roy; Lord William Bentinck – Sati declared illegal in

Bengal Presidency (later in other parts) – First major state-backed women reform.

Female Infanticide

Prevention Act (1870)

y Precedent: Bengal Regulation Acts, 180

y It had penal and surveillance provisions but suffered from weak enforcement.

Rakhmabai Case

(1884-1888)

y Rakhmabai - one of first practising women doctors in colonial India.

y The Case revolved around age of consent, marital cohabitation and restitution of

conjugal rights.

y Instrumental in the drafting of the Age of Consent Act in 1891.

Age of Consent Act (1891) y Behramji Malabari key Reformer – Act raised the age of consent for girls from 10 to 12

years but did NOT ban child marriage – Protect young girls from early marriage and

premature consummation – Opposition from extremists like Tilak (saw it as British

intrusion into Indian traditions)

Government of India Act,

1919

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Women's Indian

Association

(1917, Madras)

y Founded by Annie Besant, Margaret Cousins, Sarojini Naidu & Dorothy Jinarajadasa +

Annie Besant first president + First pan-Indian women's organisation + Core aim +

improvement of women's social, educational, legal & political status + Key issues addressed

+ women's education + child marriage + devadasi system + women's suffrage.

National Council of

Women in India (1925)

y Founder: Mehribai Tata, Lady Aberdeen + Indian branch of International Council of Women

(London) + Focussed on women's welfare, international coordination

All-India Women's

Conference (1927)

y Founded by Margaret Cousins, Maharani Chimnabai Gaekwad, Rani Sahiba of Sangli,

Sarojini Naidu, Kamla Devi Chattopadhyaya & Lady Dorab Tata + First women's

organisation with explicitly egalitarian approach + Aimed advancement of women's

education, social welfare & rights + Active participation in constitutional debates & nation-

building + Members later assume key public & political offices.

Mahila Atma Raksha

Samiti (1942)

y Founders: Joytirmoyee Ganguly, Renu Chakravarti, Mani Kuntala Sen and Kamala

Mukherjee and Ela Reid + Aimed against women exploitation during the Bengal Famine and

World War II.

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40

Pre-INC Political Organisations in India

Pre-INC political organisations in India emerged in the 19th century as early expressions of political awareness under colonial rule.

They provided platforms for educated Indians to articulate grievances and demands. These organisations laid the institutional and

ideological groundwork for the formation of the Indian National Congress.

Organisation (Year) Leaders / Key Features

Bangabhasha Prakasika

Sabha (1836)

y Founded by Bengali intelligentsia associated with Raja Ram Mohan Roy
Platform for

political awareness & discussion of administrative/public issues
Represented interests of

educated Indian elite
Among earliest organised political associations.

Zamindari Association /

Landholders' Society

(1837)

y Founders: Dwarkanath Tagore, Prasanna Kumar Tagore and Radhakant Deb in Calcutta,

Rajkamal Sen and Bhabani Charan Mitra
An association of landholders from Bengal,

Bihar, and Orissa
Primarily to protect zamindari class interests
Beginning of an

organised political activity and use of constitutional methods.

Bengal British India

Society (1843)

y Founded by George Thompson, Dwarkanath Tagore, Chandra Mohan Chatterjee & Parmananda Maitra
Aim
civic awareness + administrative reform
Methods

peaceful, constitutional
Loyal to British Crown

British Indian

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Trade Unions in British India

Trade unions in British India emerged in the late 19th to early 20th century as organised responses to industrialisation and colonial

economic conditions. They sought to represent workers' interests in emerging industries. These unions marked the beginning of

organised labour politics in India.

Union /

Organisation (Year)

Features

Bombay Mill-Hands

Association (BMHA)

(1890)

- Region: Bombay

y Founded by Narayan Meghaji Lokhande • Demanded weekly Sunday holiday; daily

30-minute lunch recess; regulated working hours; compensation for work-related injuries •

Opposed arbitrary mill closures affecting workers' wages • large participation of women

workers (notable feature) • Mill owners accept Sunday as weekly holiday (10 June 1890)

About Narayan Meghaji Lokhande

y Born in Thane, Maharashtra • Regarded as father of Indian Trade Union Movement •

His mill experience triggered labour mobilisation • Associate Member, Factory Labour

Commission (1890) • Inputs shape Factory Act (1891; implemented 1892) • Launched

labour journals; Dinbandhu + Indian Workers published from Calcutta • Conferred title

• Rao Bahadur • by British government for labour reforms • Commemorative postage stamp

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42

The Indian National Congress was founded as an all-India political platform during British rule. It provided a common forum for

educated Indians to express political grievances and aspirations. The organisation later became the central force in India's national movement.

Indian National Congress (INC)

• Reasons for Formation • Western-educated Indian middle class expands + Growth of political associations & nationalist press

+ Rising discontent with colonial economic & administrative policies

• Date & Place • 28 December 1885 at Gokuldas Tejpal Sanskrit College, Bombay (Shifted from Poona due to cholera)

• Founder & Early Leadership • Initiator: A O Hume • First President: Womesh Chandra Bonnerjee • First session: 72

delegates

• Nature (Early Phase) • Elite-led (lawyers, teachers, journalists) + Minimal mass participation

• Objectives at Inception • All-India platform via constitutional methods + Greater Indian role in administration & legislatures

+ Grievances via petitions & resolutions + National political unity

• Early Ideology & Methods (1885–1905) • Faith in British liberalism; Tools: petitions, meetings, press • Gradual reform, no

confrontation. • Known as Moderate Phase

• INC Formation Theories:

• Safety Valve Theory: Viewed as British mechanism to absorb Indian discontent • Often attributed to critics like Tilak and

later colonial interpretations.

• Lightning Conductor Theory: Channelised & unified nationalist opinion.

• Significance • First body to institutionalise nationalism + Base for later mass movements + Influenced Indian Councils Act,

1892 + Became core of freedom struggle

• High-Value Facts • Annual conference initially • Nagpur Session (1920): permanent mass party + AICC + linguistic PCCs.

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43

Session (Year, Place) President Key Developments / Resolutions

1885, Bombay W.C. Bonnerjee y Inaugural session, Moderate Constitutional methods adopted.

y Demands: Indianisation of services, reduction of military expenditure, greater Indian participation in administration.

1887, Madras Badruddin Tyabji y First Muslim President

y Emphasised national unity over communal identity.

1888, Allahabad George Yule y First English President

y Symbolised liberal British support to early Congress.

1896, Calcutta Rahimtullah M. Sayani y “Vande Mataram” sung for the first time.

y Resolution blaming British policies for famine.

y Demand for reduction of land revenue.

1899, Lucknow R.C. Dutt y Demanded end to “drain of wealth” from India.

y Demanded permanent fixation of land revenue.

1901, Calcutta Dinshaw E. Wacha y First appearance of Mahatma Gandhi on INC platform.

1905, Banaras Gopal Krishna Gokhale y Beginning of organised Swadeshi sentiment (protest against

Partition of Bengal).

y Differences between moderates and extremists came to light.

1906, Calcutta Dadabhai Naoroji y Swaraj (self-rule) adopted the INC goal.

y Condemnation of Bengal Partition.

y Resolution supporting swadeshi, boycott and national education.

1907, Surat Rash Behari Ghosh y Split within INC due to extremists’ lack of faith in the capacity of

moderates to negotiate with the British Government (Surat split).

1908, Madras Rash Behari Ghosh y Congress’ constitution was drawn, defined aims, membership

rules, and structure.

1909, Lahore Madan Mohan

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1931, Karachi Vallabhbhai Patel y Gandhi-Irwin Pact (Delhi Pact) endorsed.

y Resolution on Fundamental Rights and National Economic

Programme passed.

1936, Lucknow Jawaharlal Nehru y Emphasis on socialism

y Acceptance of left influence

1936, Faizpur Jawaharlal Nehru y First village session

y Demand for Constituent Assembly

1938, Haripura Subhas Chandra Bose y National Planning Committee set up
(Nehru as chair)

1939, Tripuri Subhas Chandra Bose

(later Rajendra Prasad)

y Bose re-elected but resigns after conflict

y Formation of Forward Bloc later

1940, Ramgarh Abul Kalam Azad y Called people to prepare for a mass civil
disobedience

(Satyagraha) movement under Mahatma Gandhi's leadership

y Demand for complete independence

1946, Meerut J.B. Kripalani y Acceptance of Cabinet Mission Plan

y Entry into Constituent Assembly

1948, Jaipur Pattabhi Sitaramayya y Congress redefined role in independent
India

y Tribute to Gandhi

Post-INC Political Organisations in India

Post-INC political organisations in India emerged alongside and after the
INC as Indian politics diversified under colonial rule. They

represented distinct regional, communal, ideological, and economic
interests. These organisations added complexity and depth to

the evolving nationalist and constitutional politics of British India.

Organisation (Year) Features

All-India Muslim League

(AIML) (1906)

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All-India Liberal

Federation (1919)

y Founded by Surendranath Banerjea, Tej Bahadur Sapru, V. S. Srinivasa Sastri, and M. R.

Jayakar – formed after a split from the Indian National Congress (INC) over the Montagu

- Chelmsford Reforms – Advocated gradual Constitutional reforms and Parliamentary

democracy + Represented many moderate leaders outside the INC.

Communist Party of

India (1925)

y Founded at Kanpur (1925) – Ideological roots – Tashkent communist activity led by M N

Roy (1920) – Marxism – Leninism – overthrow colonialism – establish socialism – end

class exploitation

y Key General Secretaries – S. V. Ghate, J. P. Bagerhatta, P C Joshi.

y Role in freedom struggle – organisation of workers – & peasants – movements – leadership

in trade unions – Meerut Conspiracy Case (faced repression) – periodic collaboration with

nationalist movements for mass mobilisation.

All-India Depressed

Classes Association

(AIDCA) (1926)

y Formed at Nagpur (1926) with first President as M C Rajah – B R Ambedkar absent at

founding due to ideological disagreement

y AIDCA stance (late 1920s) – Joint electorates + reserved seats + safeguards within

common electorate – Evolved into All India Scheduled Castes Federation (1942)

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Moderates Vs Extremists

The Moderates' Extremists differences in the Indian National Congress reflected contrasting methods and strategies in the early

national movement. Though united in the goal of self-rule, their differences shaped the course of Indian nationalism.

Aspect Moderates (1885-1905) Extremists (1905-1918)

Core Belief –

methods adopted

– Believed in gradual political reform through

constitutional means – Petitions, prayers,

resolutions, memoranda

– Believed in Complete Independence (Purna

Swaraj) through assertive mass action

– Boycott, Swadeshi, passive resistance

View of British

Rule

– British rule could be reformed – Faith in

British justice, Parliament, liberalism

– British rule was exploitative and illegitimate –

Complete distrust of British institutions

Public Participation – Limited, elite-centric leadership –

Centralised INC leadership

– Broad mass mobilisation (students, workers,

peasants) – Decentralised, regional leadership

Key Leaders – Dadabhai Naoroji, Gopal Krishna Gokhale,

Pherozeshah Mehta, Surendranath Banerjee,

W.C. Bonnerjee, M.G. Ranade, Madan

Mohan Malaviya etc.

– Bipin Chandra Pal, Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Lala

Lajpat Rai (Lal-Bal-Pal), Aurobindo Ghosh,

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Nature of Partition y Partition was implemented on 16 October 1905, Bengal divided into:

• East Bengal with Assam (Muslim-majority)

• West Bengal with Bihar and Orissa (Hindu-majority)

y First major British attempt at communal division.

Political

Significance

y Constitutional agitation • mass protest.

y Exposed limits of Moderate politics • Extremists gained space.

Outcome y Partition • widespread anti-partition movement.

y Delhi Durbar, 1911: King George V abrogated Curzon's Act • Partition annulled by Hardinge;

capital shifted Calcutta • Delhi.

y Communal mobilisation • Muslim League formed (1906) • Annulment reversed partition, not

communal politics.

Swadeshi and Boycott Movement (1905-1911)

The Swadeshi and Boycott Movement emerged in response to the partition of Bengal in 1905 and marked the beginning of mass

nationalism in India. It encouraged the rejection of foreign goods and the promotion of indigenous industries. The movement broadened

political participation and laid the ideological foundation for later phases of the freedom struggle.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements: [2023]

Statement-I:

7th August is declared as the National Handloom Day.

Statement-II:

It was in 1905 that the Swadeshi movement was launched on the same day.

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is the

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Origin y Partition of Bengal – Swadeshi Movement launched (7 August 1905, later National Handloom

Day) in Bengal, later All India reach (Bengal – Bombay, Madras, North India)

Core Objectives y Boycott of foreign goods + promotion of Swadeshi production – economic self-reliance and political self-assertion.

Key Features y First mass-based national movement before the Gandhian era – integrated economic + cultural

+ political resistance.

y Initially Moderate-led – later led by Extremists.

y Early stress on Hindu-Muslim unity; Tagore used Raksha Bandhan to promote communal

harmony.

y Core idea: Atmashakti (self-strength) – dignity, confidence, self-sufficiency.

y Samitis organised for national education & Swadeshi e.g. Dawn Society (Satish Chandra

Mukherjee founded in 1902, Calcutta), Anti-Circular Society (Sachindra Prasad Bose founded in

1905, Calcutta against Carlyle Circular – banned students participation in Swadeshi movement),

Swadesh Bandhav (Ashwini Kumar Dutt, 1905), Anushilan Samiti (Aurobindo Ghosh, Barindra

Ghosh, and Jatindranath Mukherjee) etc.

y Extremist periodicals like New India, Bande Mataram, Sandhya, Yugantar.

Methods of

Swadeshi Movement

y Boycott of foreign goods (Public bonfires + Picketing) – Parallel promotion of Swadeshi.

y Mass mobilisation tools – national songs, festivals, symbols.

y Nature: Predominantly non-violent – revolutionary tendencies emerged later.

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Lucknow Pact (1916)

Background y An agreement signed at a joint meeting of Congress (INC) and the Muslim League (ML) in December

1916 in Lucknow – sought greater Indian participation in governance.

y Sarojini Naidu called Jinnah the ‘Ambassador of Hindu-Muslim Unity’ for his efforts in bringing

INC and ML on the same platform.

Key Leaders y Bal Gangadhar Tilak (INC), Mohammed Ali Jinnah (ML) played leading roles.

Provisions y Separate electorates for Muslims agreed by Congress (reversal of its earlier stance).

y Fixed Muslim representation in Central & Provincial legislatures.

y Both Central and Provincial Legislative Councils should have a majority of elected members.

y At least half the members of the Viceroy’s and Provincial Executive Councils to be Indians.

Significance y High point of Hindu-Muslim unity – INC and ML united on constitutional reforms.

y Strengthened joint demand for self-government – raising political pressure on the British.

y Influenced the British to announce the Montagu Declaration (1917) and later the Montagu-

Chelmsford Reforms / Government of India Act, 1919 expanding Indian representation.

y Created a political atmosphere conducive to later mass movements (Non-Cooperation, Khilafat).

Limitations y Institutionalised communal politics via separate electorates.

y Over-representation in some provinces sowed future discord.

Home Rule Movement

• Background – World War I + Irish Home Rule Movement

• Causes – Political inactivity due to – The Congress split (1907) – Tilak’s imprisonment in Mandalay (1908–14) – Failure

of 1909 Act (against self-rule)

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The revolutionary movements in British India emerged as an alternative strand of the national struggle, advocating armed resistance against colonial rule. Active from the late 19th century to the 1930s, they operated through secret societies and militant actions. These movements reflected the impatience of radical nationalists and contributed to the broader momentum of the freedom struggle.

Major Revolutionary

Movements of British India

Causes of Revolutionary

Movements

- y Exploitative British rule + recurrent famines → deepened anti-British resentment.

- y Curzon-era measures (Calcutta Corporations Act, 1899; Official Secrets Act, 1904;

- Indian Universities Act, 1904, Bengal Partition (1905)) → youth radicalisation.

- y Moderate methods perceived as ineffective → emergence of Extremist phase.

- y Disillusionment of revolutionaries with the Constitutional process post-Surat split.

- y Defeats of Italy by Ethiopia (1896) + Russia by Japan (1905) → broke the myth of

European invincibility.

- y Russian Revolution (1917) + Irish struggle → inspiration for Marxist, socialist, trade

unionism, proletarian ideas.

- y Radical Journals (Atmasakti, Sarathi, Bijoli) → glorification of sacrifice, violence.

- y Gandhi's withdrawal of NCM → youth dis-illusionment → sought violence.

- y Revolutionaries rejected Congress's gradualism → sought complete independence, and

endorsed violence.

Movement / Event (Year) Features

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Muzaffarpur Conspiracy /

Alipore Bomb Case (1908) in

Bengal presidency

y Khudiram Bose and Prafulla Chaki attempted to assassinate Douglas Kingsford by

bombing his carriage.

y Outcome: Two European women were killed + arrests and a major conspiracy trial +

Prafulla Chaki died by suicide; Khudiram Bose was tried (later executed).

Nasik Conspiracy (1909) y Anant Laxman Kanhere assassinated A. M. T. Jackson, the District Magistrate of

Nashik, at the Sangeet Sharda Theatre.

y V. D. Savarkar had sent Browning pistols to India; one used in the assassination.

y Outcome: Savarkar convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment in the Cellular Jail,

Andaman (1910).

Hindustan Republican

Association (HRA, 1924),

Later turned into HSRA in

1928

y Founded by Ram Prasad Bismil, Jogesh Chandra Chatterjee, and Sachin Sanyal after

NCM withdrawal + to organise armed revolution + establish a Federal Republic of

India + Renamed HSRA under Bhagat Singh (1928) + collective leadership and socialist influence + HSRA influenced by Gita, Anandmath, Aurobindo, Vivekananda;

Russian/French/Irish revolutions.

Kakori Conspiracy (1925) in United Provinces (to raise funds for the freedom struggle).

y 9 August 1925: HRA members led by Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqulla Khan, and

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Ghadar Party / Ghadar

Movement (1913) in USA and

Canada

y Founded in San Francisco by Indian expatriates (USA–Canada) – armed overthrow

of British rule in India + complete independence (rejects Dominion Status) – name

derived from weekly Ghadar (–‘Revolution’) – mass support from Indian migrants on

US/Canadian West Coast – Ghadar newspaper circulated globally among Indians

y Leadership spectrum – Baba Sohan Singh Bhakna (President), Lala Har Dayal, Kartar

Singh Sarabha, Bhai Parmanand, Rash Behari Bose, Barakatullah, Tarak Nath Das –

cross-communal (Sikh–Hindu–Muslim) diaspora unity

y WWI phase – plan to trigger mutiny in British Indian Army – arms-smuggling –

coordinated uprisings – part of Hindu–German Conspiracy – Ghadar Mutiny

attempt – largely fails – arrests & executions after trials (incl. Lahore Conspiracy

Case linkages) – Post-war trajectory – split into communist & socialist strands –

decline – formal dissolution (1948).

Komagata Maru Incident

(1914) in Canada

y Japanese steamship carrying Indian migrants denied entry under exclusionary

immigration laws – Admission allowed only for 24 passengers – 352 refused

landing – Ship forced to return to Calcutta (Kolkata) – On arrival attempt to arrest

passengers – Riot erupts – police firing – 22 Indians killed – symbol of racial

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Gandhi's Early Life in South Africa (1893-1914)

Gandhi's years in South Africa marked the formative phase of his political and moral development. It was during this period that he

confronted racial discrimination and evolved the principles of satyagraha and non-violent resistance. These experiences profoundly

shaped his leadership and methods in India's freedom struggle.

Gandhi's Early Life in South Africa (1893-1914)

Background y Gandhi arrived in South Africa in 1893 to represent an Indian firm in a legal case.

y Pietermaritzburg train incident (7 June 1893): Being thrown out of a first-class compartment, he

catalysed his resolve to fight racial injustice.

Organisation and

Mobilisation

y Founded Natal Indian Congress (1894) to organise Indians against discriminatory laws â†' Started

the Indian Opinion (1903) newspaper, to expose discrimination and build support; later moved it to

Phoenix Settlement â†' Set up Phoenix Settlement (1904) near Durban as a communal living and

non-violent practice; centre influenced by John Ruskin's ideas.

Evolution of

Satyagraha

y First Satyagraha (1906) â†' against Transvaal Asiatic Ordinance / Asiatic Registration Laws â†'

beginning of organised civil resistance

y Subsequent struggles â†' poll tax + restrictions on movement & trades

y Boer War phase (1899–1902) â†' Gandhi organises Indian Ambulance Corps â†' voluntary service

to counter racial prejudice â†' Gandhi arrested and imprisoned for defiance of discriminatory laws

y Tolstoy Farm (1910), near Johannesburg â†' residential + training centre â†'

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Ahmedabad

Mill Strike

(Gujarat, 1918)

y Context / Shift – Mahatma Gandhi engages urban industrial labour for mass mobilisation

y Background – Plague crisis (1917) – mill owners grant 75% plague bonus to retain workers

March 1918 – decision to withdraw plague bonus (Immediate Cause)

y Deadlock

Workers' demand – 50% wage hike

Mill owners' stand – complete withdrawal of bonus

y Gandhian Intervention – At request of Anusuya Sarabhai – Method – fast (self-suffering) as

moral pressure – Compromise reached – 35% wage increase to workers – First use of fasting by

Gandhi as a political tool in India.

Kheda

Satyagraha

(Gujarat, 1918)

y First Gandhian instance of Non-Cooperation in the national movement

y Background – Monsoon failure (1918) – crop loss + high prices – peasant distress in Kheda

y Peasant sought Revenue remission due to crop failure on legal basis (revenue remission due if yield <

25% of normal output) – Government rejects remission – enforces revenue collection

y Gandhian Intervention – Mahatma Gandhi advises withholding revenue – non-violent resistance

– Collection restrained – dues taken only from those who could pay – No land confiscations

Movement called off after partial relief

y Other Key Participant – Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Narahari Parikh, Indulal

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Jallianwala

Bagh

Massacre,

1919

y Precursor – Rowlatt Satyagraha (1919) – peaceful anti-Rowlatt meetings in Amritsar

y 9 Apr 1919 – Lt. Governor Sir Michael O’Dwyer orders arrest of Dr. Saifuddin Kitchlew + Dr.

Satyapal – 10 Apr 1919 – peaceful protests for release – troops fire – civilian deaths

y Massacre – 13 Apr 1919 (Baisakhi) – >15,000 gather at Jallianwala Bagh (incl. Golden Temple

pilgrims) – Brig. Gen. Reginald Dyer seals exits – indiscriminate firing (~10 minutes), no warning –

Casualties – Official: 379; Indian estimate: 1,000+

y Immediate Repression – Martial Law imposed – Lahore, Amritsar, Gujranwala, Gujarat – summary

trials (court-martial) to crush resistance

y Indian Response – Nationwide outrage – Mahatma Gandhi returns Kaiser-i-Hind – INC non-

official inquiry committee; included Motilal Nehru, C.R. Das, Abbas Tyabji, M.R. Jayakar

– Rabindranath Tagore renounces Knighthood

y British Response – Hunter Commission (1920) appointed.

Hunter

Commission

(14 Oct 1919)

y Set up as Disorders Inquiry (Hunter) Commission – probe Jallianwala Bagh massacre

y Brig. Gen. Dyer defends firing – claims necessity to punish defiance & restore authority

y Findings – Commission condemns firing – terms actions unjustified &

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Aspect Non-Cooperation Movement (1920–1922) Khilafat Aandolan (1919–1924)

Background /

Cause

y Rowlatt Act: Detention without trial –

Satyagraha.

y Impact of the brutal Jallianwala Bagh massacre.

y Failure of Montford Reforms

y The British backtracked on wartime promises made to Indians in return for support during the War.

y Treaty of Sevres (1920): Harsh post-

World War-I terms on Turkey deeply

offended Muslims worldwide.

y British removal of the Turkish Caliph

triggered the Khilafat Movement in India.

Key Leadership y Mahatma Gandhi y Muhammad Ali, Shaukat Ali

Core Objective y At the Calcutta Session (1920), the INC adopted the attainment of Swaraj through legitimate and peaceful means as its objective.

y Protection of Caliph and Islamic holy places

Nature y National, political, non-violent y Religious issue with political mobilisation

Main Programme y Relinquishing titles, honorary offices + Boycott schools, courts, foreign cloth+ panchayat establishment

y Boycott and protest against British policy

Symbols y Khadi, charkha, renunciation of titles y Pan-Islamic solidarity

Mass

Participation

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Achievements y Motilal Nehru became Leader of Opposition;

Vithalbhai Patel elected Speaker.

y United leaders like Jinnah, Malaviya and Lala Lajpat

Rai. â†’ Popularised Swaraj

y Defeated the Public Safety Bill (1928).

y no-confidence motions, budget criticism against the government.

y But failed to wreck councils structurally

y Kept the national movement alive during lull phases.

y Sustained mass participation for future agitations.

y Reached towards villages and illiterate masses through constructive work.

End / Merger y Gradual decline after 1925 y Continued till Gandhian return

Simon Commission

The Simon Commission was a statutory body appointed by the British government in 1927 to review constitutional reforms in India.

Its all-British composition triggered widespread political opposition across the country. The commission became a symbol of colonial

disregard for Indian political aspirations and intensified nationalist mobilisation.

Background

About Simon

Commission (1927)

(Chairman - Sir John

Simon)

y Indian Statutory Commission â†’ Appointed â†’ 8 Nov 1927 â†’ under Government of India Act,

1919 â†’ appointed 2 years ahead of schedule (early statutory review) â†’ Arrived in India on 3

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Civil Disobedience Movement (1930-34)

The Civil Disobedience Movement was a major phase of India's national movement launched under Mahatma Gandhi's leadership

in 1930. It represented a mass challenge to colonial authority through non-violent defiance of British laws. The movement broadened

popular participation and significantly shaped the course of the freedom struggle in the 1930s.

Civil Disobedience Movement (1930-34)

y A mass non-violent resistance campaign against unjust British colonial laws and authority, initiated by Mahatma Gandhi in

1930 aimed to challenge British authority by refusing obedience to unjust laws.

y 12 March 1930 (launch) by Mahatma Gandhi from Ahmedabad with 78 followers
â†' Started with the Dandi March to break

the salt laws â†' April 5, 1930: Reaches Dandi (Gujarat) coast â†' April 6, 1930: Breaks salt law â†' formally starts Civil

Disobedience Movement â†' Gandhi declared: "Sedition has become my religion."

y Also Known As: Salt Satyagraha, because it began with violating the British salt tax and monopoly.

y Phase: Second major mass movement after the Non-Cooperation Movement.

y Significance: First time Congress openly demanded complete independence (Purna Swaraj) from British rule.

y Following the mass violation of the Salt Law, the colonial government declared the Indian National Congress illegal.

Background and Triggers

Event Significance

Calcutta Session y In 1928 Session, Nehru Report was endorsed â†' demanded Dominion Status for India.

Irwin's Declaration

(Oct 1929)

y Viceroy Lord Irwin promised Dominion Status and a Round Table Conference after the Simon

Commission's report, but offered no timeline. â†' This delay frustrated the

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Bardoli and Kheda y Sardar Patel y Refusal to pay land revenue

United Provinces y Jawaharlal Nehru y No-revenue and no-rent campaigns

Bihar y Ambika Kant Sinha y Breaking salt law in Patna

y Champaran and Saran satyagraha

Orissa y Gopalbandhu Choudhuri y Satyagraha in Coastal regions of Balasore, Cuttack

and Puri districts

Forms of Protest

Methods Meaning

Salt law violation y Breaking monopoly on salt production

Tax refusal y Civil refusal to fund colonial rule

Boycott courts y Refrain from legal litigation

Methods Meaning

Picketing shops y Foreign cloth and liquor picketing

Resignation y Government servants resign

Non-violence y Adherence to truth and Satyagraha

Significance of the Civil Disobedience Movement

y CDM united multiple classes like peasants, workers, women, students under a common political protest and deepened mass

mobilisation across India – Cemented Satyagraha as mass tactic of freedom struggle.

y Public challenge to British economic exploitation + Enhanced political consciousness across demographics

y Reinforcement of Purna Swaraj as central demand + Laid foundation for future constitutional negotiations

y Global attention: Brutal suppression (e.g., Dharasana) was covered by international journalists, leading to global sympathy

for the Indian freedom struggle.

Round Table Conferences (RTCs)

RTCs were held in response to the Simon Commission report's shortcomings.

Aspect First RTC, 1930 Second RTC, 1931 Third RTC, 1932

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Outcomes y India to be a federation with

safeguards regarding defence

and finance

y Other departments were to be

transferred to Indian control

y 1st RTC deemed a failure due

to Congress boycott

y Differences between Congress and

minorities deepened

y MacDonald announced:

â™| Creation of NWFP and Sindh

as Muslim-majority provinces

â™| Formation of an Indian

Consultative Committee

â™| Committees on franchise,

finance, and states

â™| Indicated the possibility of a

unilateral British Communal

Award

y White Paper laid out

Britainâ€™s constitutional plan

for India (March 1933).

y These proposals resulted in

the GoI Act, 1935

Gandhi-Irwin Pact (1931)

The Gandhi-Irwin Pact was a political agreement signed in March 1931 between Mahatma Gandhi and Viceroy Lord Irwin during

the Civil Disobedience Movement. It marked a temporary truce between the British government and the Indian National Congress.

The pact created the political context for renewed constitutional dialogue

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Significance of the

Pact

- y Recognised INC's political legitimacy; validated non-violent resistance.

- y Paved way for constitutional reforms & self-governance; accelerated the independence process.

Communal Award (1932)

The Communal Award was announced by the British government in 1932 to address minority representation in India. It formed part

of the colonial approach to constitutional reform during a period of intense political negotiation. The award had far-reaching

consequences for Indian politics and social relations.

Background y August 16, 1932: Announced by the British PM Ramsay MacDonald

- y Based on the recommendations of Indian Franchise Committee's (Lothian Committee)

Key

Provisions

- y Separate electorates extended to Muslims + Europeans + Sikhs + Indian Christians + Anglo-Indians +

Depressed Classes + Women + Marathas (Bombay Presidency)

- y Reserved representation to 78 seats reserved for Depressed Classes to Minorities granted reserved

seats across provinces

- y Electoral mechanics to Double vote for Depressed Classes to one in separate electorate + one in

general electorate to Weightage to Muslims where they were a minority

- y Legislative expansion to Provincial legislature seats doubled to allocation on communal basis

- y Women's representation to 3% reservation for women in all provinces except NWFP

- y Seats earmarked for labourers, landlords, traders, industrialists.

Reactions y Congress to Opposes separate electorates to avoids formal stand without minority consent

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Ideological Differences Between Mahatma Gandhi and Dr. B. R. Ambedkar

Dimension Mahatma Gandhi B.R. Ambedkar

Caste and Varna y Opposed untouchability; accepted reformed

varna

y Rejected caste and varna entirely

Method of Social

Change

y Moral reform; non-violence; mass

mobilisation

y Legal-constitutional reform; rights-based

approach

Separate Electorates

(SCs)

y Opposed; favoured joint electorates y Supported initially; accepted reserved seats

after Poona Pact

Role of State y Limited state (towards stateless society);

self-regulation

y Strong state for social justice

Villages and Economy y Village-centric; trusteeship based y Critic of village society; pro-industrialisation

Democracy y Swaraj with social harmony y Political democracy requires social democracy

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The 1937 provincial elections were held under the Government of India Act, 1935, introducing provincial autonomy in British India.

They marked the first major experiment in representative governance with Indian-led ministries. The elections significantly influenced

the political trajectory of the freedom struggle in the years preceding independence.

1937 Elections

Background y Held under the Government of India Act, 1935; first major provincial elections in British India.

y Followed the withdrawal of the Civil Disobedience Movement (CDM), prompting debate in the

national movement on strategy.

y Congress, despite earlier opposition to the 1935 Act, decided to contest the elections.

Key Features y Nature – Elections to Provincial Legislative Assemblies under GOI Act, 1935

y Congress Dilemma

– Internal debate – constructive work vs council politics vs continuing CDM

– Gandhi permits diversity – AICC Parliamentary Board (1934) formed – Lucknow Session (1936)

– contest elections – reject 1935 Act – adopt socialist orientation – postpone office acceptance

initially

y Congress 1937 Manifesto – Fight (not cooperate with) 1935 Act –

Commitments – civil liberties –

release of prisoners – peasant & labour welfare – abolition of untouchability – women's equality –

khadi & village industries

y Result – Congress wins 716 / 1161 seats – Forms ministries in 6 provinces – largest party elsewhere

y Congress Ministries (1937–39): Key Outcomes

– Ministers' salary capped at ₹1,500/month – modest travel norms

– Civil liberties restored – prisoners released – press freed

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Background (1930s) y Socialism gained momentum due to international factors like the Great Depression and Soviet

industrial success, and internal factors such as radicalised youth aligning with workers' and

peasants' causes.

Nehru's views y As per Nehru, Congress should become a mass, class-based movement by supporting kisan sabhas

and trade unions and raising peasant, worker demands.

Opposition to

Struggle-Truce-

Struggle Strategy

y Struggle – truce – struggle strategy – cycles of mass protest (struggle) – temporary pause (truce)

– Purpose – regroup movement + enable negotiations + resume struggle with greater force

y Socialist critique – Inspired by Socialist Revolution – Jawaharlal Nehru + other socialists

oppose pauses – Argument – national movement should be continuous confrontation – Goal –

uninterrupted struggle until imperialism overthrown

Congress Socialist

Party (1934)

y The Congress Socialist Party advocated decentralized socialism in which co-operatives, trade

unions, independent farmers, and local authorities would hold a substantial share of the economic

power.

No office acceptance y Post the passage of Government of India Act, 1935, a faction of congress was in favour of

participating in elections, however, Jawaharlal Nehru, Subhash Bose, and Congress socialists and

communists were opposed to office acceptance.

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Nationalists

Response

y Gandhi – supported Britain in the war due to his dislike for fascist ideology and advocated

unconditional support to the Allied powers – gave a call for limited Satyagraha

y Nehru – Recognised anti-fascist struggle but opposed Indian participation without independence

and also rejected immediate civil disobedience.

– Later, Gandhi decided to go with Nehru's position, which was adopted by the Congress

Working Committee (CWC).

y Socialists (Subhas Bose, JP Narayan, Acharya Narendra Dev): Viewed war as imperialist and

advocated civil disobedience to take advantage of Britain's weakness.

CWC Resolution y Condemned fascist aggression + Rejected Britain's claim of fighting for democracy while denying

it to India + Decided not to support the war – Led to resignation of Congress ministries (after the

Linlithgow statement).

British Response y Linlithgow's Statement (17 Oct 1939) – Promised consultation and a consultative committee. –

No clarity on war aims.

y Imposed Defence of India Ordinance, curtailing civil liberties.

y Treated Congress as an adversary and relied on Muslim League and princes.

Individual Satyagraha (1940)

Background y Launched by Mahatma Gandhi in 1940 after the failure of the August Offer.

y A limited, controlled protest against India's forced participation in World War II.

Features y Satyagrahis were personally chosen by Gandhi.

y Focused on asserting freedom of speech while maintaining non-violence.

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Cripps Mission (1942)

The Cripps Mission was a British constitutional initiative sent to India in March 1942 during World War II, led by Sir Stafford Cripps

to secure Indian political cooperation in the war amid growing nationalist pressure. The failure of the mission marked a decisive

breakdown in negotiations and directly preceded the launch of the Quit India Movement later in 1942.

Indian National Movement

1942-1947

Cripps Mission (March 1942)

Background y Led by Stafford Cripps, sent to India in March 1942 to secure Indian cooperation in World War II, in

response to the Pearl Harbor attack (Dec 1941) and subsequent Allied setbacks in Southeast Asia

(fall of Singapore and Rangoon).

Reasons y Growing Japanese threat to India in WW-II + Pressure from USA, USSR, and China on Britain to win

Indian support

y Failure of the August Offer (1940) + Demand for a separate Pakistan by the Muslim League.

Proposals or

Provisions

y Proposed ‘dominion status’™ for India after World War II + Viceroy retained full powers; British

control over defence till war ended.

y Constituent Assembly + Members indirectly elected by provincial legislatures + Princely States to

nominate representatives

y Right of Provinces + Free to opt out of the proposed Constitution + Non-accepting provinces allowed

separate agreement with Britain on future status.

Indian

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Background y Failure of the Cripps Mission deepened Indian frustration; despite support for the anti-Fascist cause, continued colonial rule was seen as intolerable.

y The Congress resolved to press decisively for independence through mass action.

y Also known as the August Kranti or Bharat Chhodo Andolan.

y It marked a decisive break from earlier constitutional and satyagraha-based struggles.

Reasons y Failure of the Cripps Mission (1942).

y India dragged into World War II without consent.

y Severe economic hardship, shortages, and inflation during the war.

y Rising nationalism after Civil Disobedience, Individual Satyagraha, and experience of Congress rule

(1937-39).

y Japanese advances in Southeast Asia exposed British military weaknesses.

y British support to Muslim League's separatist stance.

Features y Launch & Aim (8 Aug 1942) â†’ AICC, Bombay adopts Quit India Resolution â†’ Gandhi's call â€œDo or

Dieâ€• â†’ demands immediate British withdrawal + provisional national government.

y Nature of Movement â†’ All-India mass upsurge â†’ forced exit strategy â†’ Leaderless phase (from

9 Aug 1942) â†’ top leadership arrested â†’ decentralised, spontaneous resistance â†’ termed most

â€œun-Gandhianâ€• phase â†’ Underground networks sustain struggle â†’ coordination, morale, logistics

â†’ Usha Mehta's underground radio (Bombay) â†’ Parallel governments emerge in pockets â†’

challenge colonial authority

â†’ Broad participation â†’ students, peasants, tribals, women, officials

â†’ Key leaders at ground/underground level â†’ J.P. Narayan + Ram Manohar Lohia + Aruna Asaf Ali

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Bengal y The movement was mainly urban, marked by protests, sabotage, damage to essential services.

y Worker, tribal, and peasant movements gained momentum by linking with the Quit India Movement.

Western India y In districts like East Khandesh, Satara, Broach, and Surat, peasants carried out guerrilla attacks on

government property, communications, and British supporters.

y Gujarat saw the establishment of the "Azad Government" in Ahmedabad.

y Bombay was influenced by underground publications such as the Bombay Provincial Bulletin, Do or

Die, and Free India.

South India y K. T. Bhashyam, a Bangalore-based Congress leader active in trade unions and strikes.

Parallel Governments

Region Significant Activities

Ballia

(August 1942)

y Led by Chittu Pandey â†’ Released many Congress leaders imprisoned during the freedom struggle.

Tamluk

(1942-44)

Leader: Satish

Chandra Samanta

y Jatiya Sarkar undertook cyclone relief work â†’ sanctioned grants to schools â†’ rich supplied paddy

to the poor.

y Organised Vidyut Vahinis (electricity units).

Satara (1943-45)

Leader: Y. B.

Chavan, Nana

Patil

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Revival of INA

under Subhas

Chandra Bose

(1943)

y July 1943: Bose arrived in Singapore – Took over leadership of the INA – Recast it as a national

liberation army – Shifted its character from a Japanese-linked force to an independent anti-

colonial army.

y Azad Hind Fauj (Second INA) – Formed by merging remnants of First INA – Reinforced with

mass Indian civilian volunteers in Southeast Asia – Mobilisation driven by Bose's leadership and

call to overthrow British rule.

y Command & Organisation – Single, centralised command under Netaji – ensured discipline and

unity – regiments not community-based – Named after national leaders – fostered nationalist

unity – ~60,000 troops – Gandhi Brigade; Azad Brigade; Nehru Brigade

y Women in INA – Formation of Rani Jhansi Regiment – First all-women combat unit in modern

Indian military history – Led by Lakshmi Sehgal (Captain Lakshmi Swaminathan)

y Affiliation – Volunteers of Indian Independence League (IIL) attached to INA units – Soldiers took

oath of loyalty to Netaji and the national cause, not to any foreign power

y Assertion of Sovereignty – INA projected itself as a government-in-arms – Issued its own currency

and postage stamps – Used distinct national symbols – claim of political legitimacy

y National Symbols & Identity – Indian Tricolour adopted as national flag – Jana Gana Mana

adopted as national anthem – Lyrics by Rabindranath Tagore

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Rajagopalachari Formula (1944)

Background y During World War II, Britain froze constitutional progress until Congress and Muslim leaders reached

agreement. • The Muslim League pressed for Pakistan, while the Indian National Congress opposed

partition, creating a political deadlock. • To break this impasse, C. Rajagopalachari, a close associate

of Mahatma Gandhi, proposed the C.R. (Rajaji) Formula.

Key Proposals y It called for the Muslim League to support Congress's demand for complete independence • Muslim

League to cooperate with Congress to form a provisional government at the Centre.

y Post-war plebiscite in Muslim-majority areas of NW and NE India to decide on a separate sovereign

state.

y If partition occurred, joint safeguards for defence, commerce, and communications.

y Proposals operative only after full transfer of power by Britain.

Response y Mahatma Gandhi endorsed the formula as a potential compromise.

y Jinnah: Rejected the C R Formula and insisted on two-nation theory, Muslim-only plebiscite, and

opposed a common Centre.

y Congress: Open to cooperation with Muslim League for independence.

y Hindu leaders, like Savarkar, strongly condemned the C R Formula, viewing it as a betrayal of Hindu

interests and an endorsement of communal division.

Desai Liaquat Pact (1945)

Background y 1942–45 • while Gandhi and the CWC were jailed during QIM, Bhulabhai Desai was one of the free

leaders who held secret talks with Liaquat Ali Khan to seek a Congress-League coalition and end the

political deadlock.

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71

Naval Mutiny / Royal Indian Navy (RIN) Mutiny (1946)

Features y Background: WW-II expansion of RIN – wider recruitment beyond martial races, economic hardship,

racial discrimination, exposure to global nationalist ideas.

y Began on 18 February 1946 at HMIS Talwar, Bombay – often called the ‘Last War of Indian

Independence’. – Involved 20,000+ ratings, 78 ships & shore establishments – spread to Karachi,

Calcutta, Cochin; enjoyed public sympathy.

y Key leaders: Salil Shyam, B. C. Dutt, Madan Singh, Rishi Dev Puri, and M. S. Khan, without any central

political leadership.

Causes y Denial of fair pay and grievance redressal.

y Inferior medical facilities and menial duties.

y Poor food, harsh working conditions leading to the slogan of ‘No Food No Work’.

y Appointment of Arthur Frederick King, a racist officer, at HMIS Talwar.

y Inspiration from Quit India Movement and INA trials (1945).

Nature of

protest

y Demand for release of nationalist leaders.

y Slogans: ‘Jai Hind’, ‘Inquilab Zindabad’, ‘Quit India’

y Adoption of INC tricolour flag.

Political

response

y Congress and Muslim League opposed the mutiny; Mahatma Gandhi criticised the mutiny as

leaderless; Communist Party of India (CPI) supported the sailors.

y Unlike the 1945 INA trials, the naval ratings’ court-martials lacked a comparable high-profile, organized

legal defence.

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Cabinet Mission (1946)

Features y Members: Stafford Cripps (President of the Board of Trade), Lord Pethick-Lawrence (Secretary of State

for India), A.V. Alexander (First Lord of Admiralty).

y Background: By 1946, British rule was weakening due to the failure of Cripps Mission (1942), post-war

pressures, and RIN Mutiny, raising fears of another Quit India-type uprising.

y British objective: Urgent political settlement to avoid mass unrest and ensure a stable transition, with a

preference for a united India over Pakistan.

y Cabinet Mission arrived 24 March 1946; proposed its own plan in May 1946 due to Congress-League

deadlock.

Key

Proposals

y Rejection of Pakistan: It rejected the Muslim League's demand for a separate Pakistan, warning that

partition would create severe economic, political, and administrative problems.

y Proposed Provincial grouping:

• Section A: Hindu majority provinces (Madras, Bombay, CP, UP, Bihar and Orissa)

• Section B: Muslim majority provinces (Punjab, NWFP, Sindh)

• Section C: Bengal and Assam (having significant Muslim population)

y Proposed a three-tier executive and legislative framework, with a Union Centre (Foreign Affairs,

Defence, Communications), Sections/Groups of provinces (Sections A, B, C), and individual Provinces.

y Constituent Assembly: 389 members (292 provinces, 4 Chief Commissioners' provinces, 93 princely

states); indirectly elected by the Provincial Legislative Assemblies, using Proportional Representation

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Drafting Committee (Formed: 26 August 1947)

y Dr. B.R. Ambedkar – Chairman of the Drafting Committee.

y Other members: Alladi Krishnaswami Ayyar, N. Gopalaswami Ayyangar, K.M. Munshi, Mohammad Saadulla, B.L. Mitter

(replaced by N. Madhava Rao), and D.P. Khaitan (replaced by T.T. Krishnamachari).

Interim Government (1946-47)

y Formed on 2 September 1946 from the Constituent Assembly as per the Cabinet Mission Plan.

y League participation – Muslim League initially boycotted the Interim Government – Joined on 26 October 1946 after

negotiations with Viceroy Lord Wavell, primarily to advance the demand for Pakistan – Only central executive where

Congress and Muslim League shared power – functioned till Independence and Partition.

y Transitional administration between colonial rule and democratic governance which enjoyed considerable autonomy.

y Formation: Drawn from the Constituent Assembly elected indirectly by provincial legislatures – Congress: 208 seats,

Muslim League: 73 seats.

y Structure: Replaced the Viceroy's Executive Council with a Council of Ministers.

y Leadership: Jawaharlal Nehru as Vice President and de facto Prime Minister.

Member Portfolio(s)

Jawaharlal Nehru

(INC)

y Vice-President of the Executive

Council; External Affairs and

Commonwealth Relations

Vallabhbhai Patel

(INC)

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Independence with Partition (1947)

Mountbatten Plan

and the Partition

y Mountbatten Plan announced (3 June 1947) by Lord Mountbatten – Partition accepted by all

major parties (despite Gandhi's opposition) – Leads to Indian Independence Act, 1947

y Freedom with Partition – Two independent Dominions created (India + Pakistan) – Posts of

Viceroy & Secretary of State for India abolished

– Governor-Generals appointed – Mountbatten (India) – Muhammad Ali Jinnah (Pakistan)

y Princely States provision – Free to accede to India/Pakistan or remain independent

y Constituent Assemblies – Separate Constituent Assembly for Pakistan – Indian Constitution not

applicable to Muslim-majority areas joining Pakistan

y Provincial decisions – Punjab & Bengal legislative assemblies vote for partition – provinces

divided on religious lines – Sind joins Pakistan – NWFP referendum – votes for Pakistan

(boycotted by Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan)

y Boundary demarcation – Radcliffe Commission constituted – Chaired by Sir Cyril Radcliffe –

Task – draw international boundary between India & Pakistan.

Congress and the

Partition

y Congress unable to dissuade Jinnah or counter British backing of Muslim League – Earlier

cooperation collapses – Lucknow Pact + NCM – Khilafat – breakdown by WWII phase –

Political compulsion – limited Muslim mass mobilisation by Congress – reluctant acceptance of

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Journals, books, and newspapers in modern India played a crucial role in spreading political awareness and nationalist ideas. They

served as platforms for debate, criticism of colonial rule, and social reform. The print media significantly contributed to the growth

of public opinion and the national movement.

Publication (Year) Author / Editor Type and Language Key Features

The Bengal Gazette/

Calcutta General

Advertiser

y James Augustus

Hickey

y Weekly English

Newspaper from Calcutta

started in 1780

y First newspaper in India

y Hickey started exposing the

corrupt tendencies of Hastings and

the government

Sambad Kaumudi

(1821)

y Raja Rammohan Roy y Bengali Weekly

Newspaper

y Demand for a trial jury in

provincial courts

Mirat-ul-Akbar (1822) y Raja Rammohan Roy y Weekly Persian Journal y First journal in Persian

Bombay Samachar

(1822)

y Fardoonji Murazban y Gujarati Newspaper

(Began as weekly, later

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The Hindu (1878) y G. Subramania Iyer y English Newspaper

(Began as weekly, later

became daily)

y Opposed colonial policies; early

nationalist English daily

Kesari (1881) y Bal Gangadhar Tilak y Weekly Marathi

Newspaper

y Assertive nationalism; mass

mobilisation

y Tilak jailed for writings

Mahratta (1881) y Bal Gangadhar Tilak y Weekly English

Newspaper

y English articulation of extremist

nationalism; companion to ‘Kesari’

Swadesamitran (1882) y G. Subramania Iyer y Began as weekly Tamil

Newspaper, later became

daily

y First Indian Tamil daily; nationalist

voice

Anandamath (1882) y Bankim Chandra

Chattopadhyay

y Bengali Novel y Cultural nationalism

y Includes Vande Mataram

Sudhakar (1888)

(Pune)

y Gopal Ganesh

Agarkar

y Anglo Marathi Weekly

Marathi Newspaper

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77

The relationship between the national movement and the princely states evolved gradually under British rule. Initially limited,

nationalist influence expanded as political awareness spread within the states. This interaction became an important dimension

of India's struggle for independence.

National Movement

and Princely States

Influence of the

National

Movement over

Princely States

y Nationalism spreads beyond British India → political awakening in princely states → Democratic

ideals (civil liberties, responsible government) attract subjects under autocratic rulers → Initial

spread via individual nationalists (incl. some British-India revolutionaries) → Later phase → mass

character with popular mobilisation

y Praja Mandals / State Peoples' Conferences formed in Key states → Mysore, Baroda, Hyderabad,

Indore, Kathiawad, Jamnagar, Nawanagar → Function → organise citizens → demand civil rights &

accountable governance

y New leadership emerges → Maniklal Kothari → Balwantrao Mehta → C. R. Abhayankar

y All-India coordination (1927) → Bombay Conference → formation of All India States People's

Conference → Role → common platform for political action in princely states.

Indian National

Congress (INC)

Policy towards

Princely States

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Butler

Committee

(1927)

y Appointment (1927) – Butler Committee set up under Sir Harcourt Butler – examine British

Princely States relations

y Report (1929) – Reaffirms Doctrine of Paramountcy – deliberately left undefined – Relationship

characterised as evolving & dynamic, not contractual – Paramountcy to remain with British –

safeguard princely states

y Consent principle – Princely States cannot be transferred to any new Indian government without

their consent

y Indian nationalist response – Nehru Report (1928) opposes Butler findings – Demands transfer

of paramountcy to Indian Commonwealth – Proposes Supreme Court as arbiter for Centre – State

(Union – States) disputes.

Federation

Scheme

y All-India Federation proposed – representation from British India + Princely States combined –

Constitutional design shift – Princely States linked directly with British India, not merely with the

Crown

y Mode of representation

– British India – largely elected members

– Princely States – nominated members

y Built-in conservative check – nominated princes – one-third of legislature – curb nationalist

dominance

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The Indian Freedom movement was led by leaders, thinkers, and activists who shaped India's struggle against colonial rule. They

represented diverse ideologies, regions, and methods of resistance. Their contributions collectively guided the course of the national movement.

Leaders and Key

Personalities

Personality & Identity Key contributions / Why important

Rabindranath Tagore

(1861–1941) – Poet, educator,

Bengal Renaissance leader.

• Won Nobel Prize (1913) for Gitanjali – first non-European Nobel laureate.

• Modernised Bengali prose/verse; composed – "Jana Gana Mana" and "Amar Sonar Bangla".

• Founded Visva-Bharati; renounced knighthood after Jallianwala Bagh.

Dadabhai Naoroji (1825–1917)

– Early nationalist economist

and politician.

• Propounded the Drain of Wealth Theory explaining colonial exploitation (Poverty

and Un-British Rule in India, 1901).

• Founded East India Association (1866) to voice Indian issues in Britain.

• Co-founder of INC; presided thrice (1886, 1893, 1906 sessions).

• First Indian elected to the British House of Commons (1892).

• First to formally declare Swaraj as INC's goal (1906)

Mahatma Gandhi (1869–1948)

– Leader of mass non-violent

struggle.

• Developed Satyagraha / Ahimsa (South Africa → India) → Led Champaran,

Non-Cooperation, Civil Disobedience and Quit India movements.

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Sarojini Naidu (1879–1949)

– Poet and women's nationalist

leader – Known as –Nightingale

of India–

y First Indian woman President of INC (1925); active in Non-Cooperation, Civil

Disobedience and Quit India.

y Co-founded women's organisations (Women's Indian Association) and became first

woman Governor (United Provinces).

Surendranath Banerjee

(1848–1925) – Early moderate

nationalist leader

y Founded the Indian National Association (1876).

y Campaigned against ICS age limits, Arms Act, Vernacular Press Act.

y Edited The Bengalee newspaper.

y Early architect of all-India political unity

Bal Gangadhar Tilak (1856–

1920) – Militant/ mass leader of

early nationalism and mass

mobiliser

y Proclaimed –Swaraj is my birthright– in Belgaum (now Belagavi) during the Bombay State Political Conference of 1916.

y Used Ganesh & Shivaji festivals for mass mobilisation.

y Founded Home Rule League; imprisoned for sedition (Mandalay).

B. R. Ambedkar (1891–1956)

– Social reformer, jurist,

Constitution's principal architect.

y Led Dalit rights movements (Mahad, Temple-entry campaigns).

y Negotiated Poona Pact (1932).

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Aurobindo Ghosh (1872–1950)

- Revolutionary nationalist cum

spiritual philosopher; called

“Prophet of Indian Nationalism”

by Rabindranath Tagore.

y Left civil service career; worked in Baroda State Service (from 1893)

y Key role in Bengal’s extremist movement after Bengal’s Partition.

y Associated with Anushilan Samiti and openly advocated Swaraj.

y Arrested in Alipore Conspiracy Case (1908); acquitted due to lack of evidence; it

marked his withdrawal from active politics.

y Established Sri Aurobindo Ashram (1926) at Pondicherry with Mirra Alfassa (“The

Mother”) + Developed the philosophy of Integral Yoga, emphasising spiritual growth

within worldly life.

y Works: The Life Divine, the Synthesis of Yoga, Savitri (epic poem); New Lamps For

Old ‘series of articles (1893–94) criticising the Congress for being disconnected

from the proletariat.

Vinayak Damodar Savarkar

(1883–1966) - Early revolutionary

nationalist

y Linked with Abhinav Bharat Society and India House, London.

y Authored The Indian War of Independence (1857) ‘Presented 1857 revolt as India’s first national uprising ‘banned by the British.

y Formulated Hindutva ideology, clearly expressed in Essentials of Hindutva (1923),

later published as Hindutva: Who Is a Hindu? (1928).

y Defined Indian nationhood based on common ancestry, culture, and homeland,

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The tenures of various Governor-Generals and Viceroys marked distinct phases in the evolution of British rule in India. Each period

witnessed important administrative, political, and constitutional changes.

Together, these developments shaped the structure and

functioning of colonial governance.

Governors of Bengal

Governors of Bengal Significant Events / reforms

Roger Drake

(1756-57)

y Fort William was captured by the Nawab of Bengal, Siraj ud-Daulah (June 1756).

y Black Hole of Calcutta incident became a rallying point for British retaliation.

y He fled during the 1756 Calcutta siege, exposing Company paralysis.

Robert Clive

(1757-60)

y Led British victory in Battle of Plassey – Installed Mir Jafar as Nawab of Bengal –

Company as kingmaker – Large-scale plunder and personal gains by Company officials,

under him.

y Third Carnatic War: While Clive was in Bengal, the French under Count de Lally captured

Fort St. David and Vizianagaram from the British in 1758

y 1759: Battle of Bidara (Hoogly or Chinsurah) end of Dutch by English.

Henry Vansittart

(1760-64)

y Replaced Mir Jafar with Mir Qasim as the Nawab of Bengal.

y Mir Qasim introduced administrative and revenue reforms – shifted capital from

Murshidabad to Munger to avoid British interference, reduced corruption, etc

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Sir John Shore

(1793-98)

y Tenure is characterized by a policy of strict non-intervention

y The Charter Act of 1793 passed.

y Second Rohilla War (1794): British EIC (with Nawab of Awadh) vs Rohillas of Rampur –

Rohillas defeated at the Battle of Bhitaura

y Bengal regulations (1795) to curb female infanticide in Bengal (began ~ 1795 and

intensified by 1804).

y Battle of Khorda (1795): Nizam vs the Marathas – Nizam defeated.

y A local Jacobin Club (1797) was founded at Seringapatnam by Tipu Sultan, inspired by

the ideals of the French Revolution.

Lord Richard Wellesley

(1798-1805)

y Introduced Subsidiary Alliance System (1798).

y Fourth Mysore War (1799): The British restored the Wodeyar dynasty and compelled it to

accept the Subsidiary Alliance.

y Took over the administration of Tanjore (1799), Surat (1800), and Carnatic (1801).

y Fort William College was established in Kolkata in 1800

y Treaty of Bassein (1802), Bajirao II brought under Subsidiary Alliance.

y Second Anglo-Maratha War (1803-05):

– Battle of Assaye - Defeat of Bhonsle – Treaty of Deogaon (1803).

– Battle of Laswari - Defeat of Scindia – Treaty of Surji-Anjangaon (1803).

– Defeat of Holkars – Treaty of Rajpurghat (1805).

Sir George Barlow

(1805-07)

y Vellore Mutiny (1806).

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Lord Metcalfe

(1835-36)

y Press Act, 1835 (Metcalfe Act): Abolished press licensing and censorship; earned him the

title ‘Liberator of the Indian Press.’

y The Bangabhasha Prakasika Sabha was founded in 1836.

Lord Auckland

(1836-42)

y Agra famines (1837-38): severe drought and crop failure in the North-Western Provinces.

y The Tattvabodhini Sabha was founded in 1839 by Debendranath Tagore in Calcutta.

y Death of Ranjit Singh (1839).

y First Afghan War (1838-42) and massacre of Elphinstone's army during First Anglo-

Afghan War, British retreat from Kabul (1842).

Lord Ellenborough

(1842-44)

y Somnath Proclamation (1842): return of temple gates from Ghazni.

y Annexation of Sindh (1843).

y The Bengal British India Society, founded in Calcutta (1843), by figures like Dwarkanath

Tagore and George Thompson.

y War with Gwalior (1843) established British dominance in Central India.

Lord Hardinge I

(1844-48)

y First Anglo-Sikh War (1845-46), Battle of Sobraon and the Treaty of Lahore (1846).

y Social reforms including abolition of female infanticide and human sacrifice.

Lord Dalhousie

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Lord Mayo

(1869-72)

y Rajkumar College (Rajkot) and Mayo College (Ajmer) established for political education of

Indian princes.

y The Poona Sarvajanik Sabha was founded in 1870 by M G Ranade in Pune.

y Indian Reform Association (1870), founded by KC Sen, launched the Bengali weekly Sulabh

Samachar.

y Establishment of Statistical Survey of India + Department of Agriculture and Commerce.

y Financial decentralisation (1870):

• Provincial governments were given fixed grants

• Introduction of state railways.

• Reduced financial burden on the central government.

y Assassination at Port Blair (1872) by a Wahabi convict; first and only Viceroy assassinated in

office.

Lord Northbrook

(1872-76)

y Brahmo (Native) Marriage Act, 1872 passed, permitted inter-caste unions, and fixed minimum

ages (girls 14, boys 18).

y Kuka (Namdhari) Movement in Punjab (1872).

y The Satyashodhak Samaj (Truth-Seekers' Society) founded by Jyotirao Phule (1873).

y The Singh Sabha movement (1873) to revive and purify Sikhism, promote modern Western

education.

y Bihar famine (1873-74) impacting primarily Bihar and little extent to Bengal, NW Provinces,

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Lord Elgin II

(1894-99)

y Indian famine of 1896-1897, impacting United Provinces, Deccan , Bengal, Punjab.

y Bubonic plague outbreak (1896-98).

y Vivekananda founded the Ramakrishna Mission in 1897, in Calcutta.

y W.C. Rand assassination (1897), Plague Commissioner of Pune, by the Chapekar brothers

Deportation of Natu brothers (1897) from Poona without trial.

y Annie Besant founded the Central Hindu College in Banaras in 1898 later BHU.

y Mitra Mela (1899) founded by Vinayak and Ganesh Savarkar in Nashik.

Lord Curzon

(1899-1905)

y Munda Rebellion / Ulgulan (1899-1900) led by Birsa Munda (Dharti Aba).

y The Calcutta Corporation Act (1899) reduced elected Indian representation.

y Severe famine (1899-1900) affected Central Provinces & Berar, Bombay Presidency, Ajmer-

Merwara, and Hissar (Punjab).

y The Second Boer war (1899-1902).

y Police Commission (1902) setup under Sir Andrew Fraser to review police administration.

y Anushilan Samiti established (1902).

y Universities Commission (1902) appointed + Indian Universities Act (1904) passed.

y Narayana Guru's Dharma Paripalana Movement registered as a company (1903).

y Younghusband's Mission to Tibet (1904) to counter Russian influence and settle Tibet-Sikkim

boundary Treaty of Lhasa (1904); Tibet to pay 175 lakh indemnity.

y Ancient Monuments Preservation Act (1904) passed.

y Ramabai Ranade founded Bharat Mahila Parishad (1904) in Bombay.

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Lord Irwin

(1926-31)

y Simon Commission to India (1928) and its boycott.

y An All-Parties Conference at Lucknow (1928) – Nehru Report or the Nehru Constitution.

y Harcourt Butler Indian States Commission appointed (1927).

y Saunders (assistant SP of Lahore) murder; bomb blast in the Assembly Hall of Delhi (1929).

y Lahore Conspiracy Case – death of Jatin Das after prolonged hunger strike (1929)

y INC Lahore session (1929) – Purna Swaraj Resolution.

y Dandi March (March 12, 1930) started by Gandhi.

y –Deepavali Declaration–™ by Lord Irwin related to the Dominion status (1929).

y Boycott of the First RTC (1930) – Gandhi-Irwin Pact (1931) – suspension of CDM.

Lord Willingdon

(1931-36)

y Second RTC (1931) failure – resumption of CDM.

y Communal Award (1932) announced – proposed separate communal electorates.

y –Fast unto death–™ by Gandhi in Yeravada jail, broken after the Poona Pact (1932).

y Third Round Table Conference (1932).

y The Government of India Act of 1935 passed.

y Establishment of All India Kisan Sabha (1936) and Congress Socialist Party (1934).

y Burma separated from India (1935).

Lord Linlithgow

(1936-44)

y First general elections (1936-37) – Congress emerged as the largest party and formed ministries

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